

R E P O R T

TO

HON. A. V. BROWN, POSTMASTER GENERAL,

ON THE

OPENING AND PRESENT CONDITION

OF THE

**UNITED STATES OVERLAND MAIL ROUTE BETWEEN SAN ANTONIO, TEXAS,
AND SAN DIEGO, CALIFORNIA,**

REPORT
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ON THE
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California

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK REPORT TO
HON. A. V. BROWN, POSTMASTER-GENERAL ***

**REPORT
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POSTMASTER GENERAL,
ON THE
OPENING AND PRESENT CONDITION
OF THE
UNITED STATES OVERLAND MAIL ROUTE BETWEEN SAN
ANTONIO, TEXAS, AND SAN DIEGO, CALIFORNIA,
BY
I. C. WOOD, SUPERINTENDENT.**

WASHINGTON CITY, D. C., *March —, 1858.*

SIR: In compliance with your request, I beg leave to submit the following report, showing the present condition of the mail stage line running semi-monthly between San Antonio, Texas, and San Diego, California, containing also extracts from the journal of my trip over the line and back.

I have here grouped together observations, made from time to time, along the road, of the soil, climate, distances, deserts, mountains, supplies of wood, water, and grass, arable land, pasturage, and general character of the road we stage over. I have endeavored to avoid inserting anything except what I learned from the experiences of my trip; but the statements of the distances and altitudes are from government surveys, as I had neither time to measure the road nor to ascertain its altitudes.

Extracts from my journal.

June 12, 1857.—The late James E. Birch entered into a contract with your department for the transmission of a semi-monthly mail to and from San Antonio, Texas, and San Diego, California. I had been laboring in connexion with Mr. Birch during the period in which the great overland mail letting was pending, and, in compliance with the understanding between us, I took charge of the execution of this contract.

June 15.—To-day I despatched a man from New York, with instructions to proceed at once to San Antonio, Texas, and there to purchase a suitable outfit with which to take the first mail, namely, that of July 9th, through to San Diego. That he might be able to transport the mail through in proper shape, and in schedule time if possible, I wrote a full authority for him to act in any emergency which might arise on the road, and also gave him the cash necessary to carry out these instructions. Never having travelled the road, I was of course unable to give specific directions to the first conductor, but depended, in a great degree, on his discretion.

June 20.—By the mail steamer to California to-day I forwarded full instructions to Mr. R. E. Doyle, of San Francisco, accompanied by an authority from Mr. Birch to him, in virtue of which he was to take the management of that portion of the mail line running west of Tucson. I instructed Mr. Doyle to start the first mail, if possible, on the 24th of July, from San Diego.

[I subsequently learned, and insert the facts here to make my report more connected, that these instructions reached Mr. Doyle on the 13th of July; the steamer for San Diego would sail on the 18th, thus leaving him only five days for making his preparations. Mr. Doyle agreed to take an interest, and to advance the money needed to commence service on the Pacific end of the line. The purchase and shipment of the necessary saddles, bridles, blankets, rations, arms, &c., as well as the selection of the first conductors and guard, was a work requiring more than five days. The first outfit, all but the animals, was shipped to San Diego on the 18th; the steamer arrived there on her usual time, namely, July 21st, leaving three days only in which to purchase the required animals. The difficulty in finding suitable mules proved greater than was anticipated, and the outfit, though nearly complete, could not be made ready to leave at 6 a. m. of the 24th, according to contract. The first mail for San Antonio left San Diego on the 9th of August; relays of animals having previously been sent forward to Fort Yuma.]

June 23.—From the 12th, the date of the signing of the contract, up to this date, I had been engaged in the necessary preliminary preparations for my journey to San Diego; also in making such purchases as I deemed indispensably necessary to be made in New York. My purchases in New York were limited, in comparison with the requirements of the line. I hardly knew myself what I wanted; therefore I determined to make the bulk of my purchases in San Antonio, where I hoped to get some reliable information as to my new duties.

To-day Mr. Birch gave me my authority to act for him, which authority was made out in the form of a common letter, addressed by him to me, instead of a power of attorney. His purpose was to convey to me the most unlimited powers. I enclose a copy of this document.

NEW YORK, *June 23, 1857.*

DEAR SIR: I have taken a contract with the Postmaster General to carry the United States mail between San Diego and San Antonio twice a month for four years, a copy of which contract you have been furnished with. I wish you to take charge, for me, of the fulfilment of this contract, and of any additions that may be made to it, as my general agent for the purpose. After making all preliminary arrangements which you deem proper, I desire you to proceed to the line of the route, put it into operation, and perform the service. You are authorized by me to make all the contracts, and do all things you may deem necessary or proper for the purpose, having the same authority in the premises that I would myself if present. To carry out the above, I hand you certificates of deposit—

Ten of \$1,000 each	\$10,000 00
Forty of \$200 each	8,000 00
Cash	800 00
Advanced James Mason	1,200 00
	20,000 00

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To be distributed on my account.

JAMES E. BIRCH.

Mr. I. C. WOODS.

June 24.—I left this morning for San Antonio, *via* Chicago, Cairo, and New Orleans. The only assistant I took with me was a young gentleman of liberal education, who was acquainted with English, French, and Spanish, as well as the German, his native language. I have since found that it is an indispensable requisite to the economical management of our line that all mail conductors and agents should speak the Spanish language; we make a point of this now in selecting men for our service.

July 5.—Having been detained on the way by business and railroad accidents, I only reached New Orleans the night before last, missing the mail connexion to Indianola. To-day I received a telegraphic communication from Mr. Birch, informing me that he would leave New York that day per steamer for California. It had been agreed between us that we were to meet in San Diego as soon as I could reach there.

[In the course of my journal I shall refer again to this appointment, though I deem it proper to mention here that I never saw Mr. Birch after we parted on the 23d June. He was lost in the Central America September 11th, three days after I reached the Pacific.]

July 7.—We were due in Indianola this morning at daylight, but unfortunately grounded in a fog on a sand bar at the entrance of the bay, which lost us the connexion with the coach for San Antonio. This delay prevented my attending in person to despatching the mail of the 9th from San Antonio, as I had much desired to do.

July 11.—Reached San Antonio to-day at 4 p. m.

July 13, Monday.—As my letter of authority will show, Mr. Birch gave me eighteen thousand eight hundred dollars in hand. After deducting the cost of some purchases of arms and clothing made in New York, I have, on reaching San Antonio, about seventeen thousand seven hundred dollars. With this money I commenced operations at once. To-day I hired a corral

and office, also commenced making arrangements for men, in all of which I was very kindly assisted by Mr. G. H. Giddings.

July 16.—Busily engaged in purchasing mules and the necessary articles to fit out the mail trains. To-day I hired Captain Henry Skillman as a conductor to take the mail of the 24th through to the Pimos villages, with which country he is very familiar. After this first trip through he is to run regularly on the Arizona section. Captain Skillman is, I believe, well known to your department as the first contractor for the mail between San Antonio and Santa Fé.

July 19.—To-day I despatch an extra train with stores for the road, and under instructions to go as far as Fort Lancaster, three hundred miles from here, and then to return. By this train I sent relays to be used by the up mail of the 24th, which is to be under charge of Captain Skillman. Nine mules were to be left at Fort Clarke, and eighteen at Fort Lancaster.

[This train was attacked and captured on Devil's river by the Indians. I have referred to it more particularly in the course of my journal.]

July 22.—Mr. Giddings' mail in from El Paso; they met our mail of July 9 getting along safely, though slowly.

July 24.—Punctual to the hour named in the contract, 6 a. m., I this morning despatched the mail coach from the Plaza with the through mail to San Diego. The postmaster made up mails also for all the intermediate military posts on our route, although supplying them was not at first contemplated in the contract. Desiring to manifest, from the first, a spirit of accommodation to all parties, we were happy to take charge of anything the postmaster chose to send. This mail was the second *through mail* which had left San Antonio, being at the same time the first that had been sent forward in a coach. This outfit consisted of—

One coach and harness.

Six men, well armed with rifles, and a Colt's pistol to each.

Four saddles and accoutrements.

Ropes, hobbles, shoeing tools, shoes and nails.

Cooking utensils, and numerous minor articles.

Provisions for thirty days, calculated to last to the Pimos villages and back to El Paso.

Thirty-six mules; of these, twenty-seven had been sent forward on the road as relays.

Also six hundred dollars in cash to purchase supplies on the route.

[It was twenty-one of these mules which were captured on Devil's river by the Indians; see journal of June 19 and [August 2.](#)]

[To insure this mail getting through in schedule time, if possible, I gave Capt. Skillman authority to act for the line in any emergencies which might arise. The reputation which he enjoyed in San Antonio fully warranted me in entrusting this pioneer coach to him, and I subsequently found him every way qualified for the service he had undertaken, as some interesting incidents connected with his trip will prove hereafter.]

[I will here add a brief sketch of the manner in which I had planned to send the mail through to San Diego. In my instructions of June 20 to Mr. R. E. Doyle, I had requested him to make all his arrangements to send the mails from San Diego as far east as the Pimos villages. In my plan of operation, taking San Antonio as the starting point, I would work westwardly, while with his plan of operation, with San Diego as the basis, he would work eastwardly, I proposed to make the connexions between the two systems at the Pimos villages. I calculated that Captain Skillman would reach these Pimos villages about the 17th of August, (he reached there August 20;) furthermore, that he could meet there the mail of August 9 from San Diego, and then he would return to El Paso in time to make the through connexion there with the mail train from San Antonio, which train I undertook to have in waiting. Owing to circumstances entirely beyond my control, and likely to arise only in a pioneer trip, the mail from San Diego failed to make the connexion at the Pimos villages by thirty-six hours. It was a part of the plan that Captain Skillman should purchase a complete new outfit of mules at El Paso, which he was unable to do.

At Cook's Wells he overtook the mail of July 9 from San Antonio, waiting for an escort. The two trains proceeded together under charge of Captain Skillman as far as the Pimos villages, at which point the conductor of the mail of July 9 pushed on to San Diego with both mails, reaching his

destination at 11 a. m. August 30. I have found no reason, as yet, to alter the system of mail connexion referred to in this note, though the place where we now join the eastern and western management is at Tucson, Arizona Territory. One hundred miles west of the Pimos villages each carrier now delivers the mails, and retraces the road with the return mail.]

July 29.—Since my arrival in San Antonio, I had made every possible exertion to procure mules adapted to the purpose of staging. I drove about the country myself, and sent agents to purchase wherever we heard of any good mules for sale. As yet, the right kind come in slowly.

[There was another view which I took of my position as superintendent of the line, and one which governed me throughout in all my exertions. It was this:

An understanding existed between Mr. Birch and myself, that your department desired to have the new mail service commence at once, and to have it pushed, if possible, to an early and vigorous success. It had been from the first determined to spare neither money nor labor, if either, or both combined, could by any possibility produce the desired result. I had determined to go myself over the road and back again, in as short a period of time as was consistent with the proper discharge of my duties as superintendent. I had planned to leave San Antonio on the 1st of August for El Paso, with a train consisting of coaches, mules, rations, arms, men and general equipment, to be placed on that portion of our road situated in Arizona Territory, between El Paso and the Pimos villages.

I had further planned to reach El Paso in season to purchase the necessary mules with which to carry forward, in person, the mail for San Diego of 9th August. This mail I estimated would overtake me on the 21st or 22d at the last named place.]

July 29.—After examining the subject thoroughly for several days past, I saw but one way in which to bring about the results I had in view within the time required. This was to purchase or hire the entire stock of mules and coaches used on the San Antonio and Santa Fé line, owned and run by G. H. Giddings, of San Antonio. Mr. Giddings had treated me with every possible consideration, and during the time I had been in San Antonio had rendered me as much assistance as though he had had a personal interest in the success of the enterprise. On the 26th I opened to him the matter of this

purchase which I desired to make, and to-day made a conditional purchase of all the mules, coaches, and other property used on his mail route. The bringing of this property under my superintendence, in conjunction with the stock I had already purchased, would enable me to perform our mail service of twice a month, and also Mr. Giddings' contract of once a month, with less stock than if the two lines had been run separately.

One of the most advantageous features of this arrangement with Mr. Giddings was his agreement to go to El Paso with the mail of August 9, there to remain as agent of this line during my necessary absence in California.

July 31.—This morning I despatched the train of coaches, men, and supplies, referred to [July 29](#). I shall take this train with me, and distribute it along the road wherever it is needed, principally to the west of El Paso.

This train, the fourth that had gone from San Antonio, and the third one I had sent off, consisted of three coaches and harness; seventeen men well armed with rifles, and a Colt's pistol to each; thirty-eight mules; about four thousand pounds weight of rations, and equipments for the upper end of the line; ten saddles and accoutrements; also all the smaller articles usually sent forward in one of our mail trains.

August 1.—Up to this date my personal luggage had not reached me from the coast, partly owing to my haste in leaving San Antonio, and partly to its not having been sent forward from Lavacca as speedily as it might have been after I had left it. Up to this date I have only seen my baggage once since leaving it at Lavacca the 9th of last July. It met me at El Paso, where I was compelled to leave it for want of room in my coach. To-day I left in the Santa Fé mail coach to overtake the train I sent out yesterday. We would travel together for several hundred miles.

Before I left San Antonio I completed the outfit for the up mail of August 9, in which mail Mr. Giddings was to come to El Paso, and the arrival of which I was to await there before proceeding westward on my journey.

The conductor of our train was compelled to remain all night in Castroville. This detention was in consequence of the herder having got intoxicated, and permitted six of our mules to stray. It was not prudent to go on and leave

them behind in this condition, so we remained, in the hope of finding them in the morning by daylight.

Castroville is a very pretty town picturesquely situated on the west bank of the Medina river.

We found our road thus far to be an excellent one, though dusty at this time. The country through which we passed was parched and the grass dry, yielding but little nutriment to animals. It must be taken into consideration that southwestern Texas has had a partial drought for three successive seasons; this last year was the worst of all. Corn in San Antonio, and in the surrounding country, is now brought from New Orleans and from Mexico. We pay two dollars per bushel for all we consume. In seasons of good crops corn sells in and about San Antonio at fifty cents per bushel. Made 25 miles to-day.

[When I came back over this road in January the whole country was full of water; the river was barely passable, the roads were muddy and tedious all the way from Fort Clarke to San Antonio, and the prospects of a crop were excellent.]

August 2.—Left Castroville at 4 a. m.; an hour afterwards we found five of our six missing mules grazing quietly by the road side unguarded. I thought at the time that this losing of mules was very strange, but I have since found it quite a feature in our business, and one that it is impossible to prevent. Animals are left behind because the mail cannot be detained waiting for broken down mules to recruit, or to find strayed stock. About 8 a. m. I met Captain Wallace, whom I had despatched from San Antonio on the 19th in charge of the train with relays for Captain Skillman. (See journal of [that day](#) and [July 24](#).) All that now returned of a fine outfit was the conductor and one man on borrowed mules. A drizzling rain was falling, the two discomfitted mail men were wrapped in sombre looking blankets. One of them had his arm in a sling from a wound received in the fight, and indeed their whole appearance was well calculated to give their narrative of the loss a gloomy coloring to any one not familiar with Indian depredations.

The particulars of this disaster, as I gathered them from the two men, were as follows: The train was getting along finely on its way to Fort Lancaster, being at the time of the attack eighteen miles north of *Fort Hudson*. The Indians appeared suddenly on all sides of them from the chapparal, and

commenced firing at the mules in the coach, the loose mules being a few hundred yards ahead. The frightened animals ran into a mezguer, turned short round, and broke the pole. As this accident prevented his keeping up with the *mulada* ahead, the conductor, who was driving at the time, jumped from the box, called to a young man by the name of Clifford to follow him, and went to the assistance of the men driving the herd. Clifford was either surrounded by Indians, or wounded so that he was unable to get away from the coach, and died fighting hand to hand with the Indians. The conductor got the *mulada* turned off from the road for the purpose of making a detour to escape his pursuers; but the chase was so hot, and one saddle mule having to be double mounted, they were compelled to betake themselves to running and leave the mules and property to their fate.

We lost coach and harness, twenty-one mules, provision and equipment, one hundred dollars in money, and one box of personal property valued at some hundreds of dollars, belonging to a sergeant's wife at Fort Lancaster.

The Indians were supposed to be Camanches.

At Fort Hudson the conductor found a scouting party, of the second cavalry, from Fort Clarke. They had been on the Rio Grande, examining well known Indian trails which lead into Mexico. Captain Whiting, the officer in command of this scouting party, immediately started on the trail of the Indians who had captured our train. A party of infantry was kindly sent out by Lieutenant Fink, commanding at Fort Hudson, for the purpose of burying young Clifford and of bringing in the broken coach, if worth preservation.

Captain Whiting overtook the Indians and recaptured nearly all our mules, though many of them we found were ruined for stage purposes.

The accident was rather a disagreeable one to come upon us, in the outset of our enterprise. It seemed to place a number of great obstacles in my way. I hardly knew how to prevent its being repeated, or whether such attacks were to be of common occurrence. I knew not where to look for mules to replace those stolen, as good stage animals were not plenty in or about San Antonio. That which seemed another risk presented itself in the fact that Captain Skillman was only a few days behind Wallace's train; this naturally suggested the thought that perhaps the Indians would remain concealed among the cañons of Devil's river until he came along, and cut him off. On

the other hand there seemed a chance that they would let a mail party like his pass unmolested, preferring to try us because we had a large *mulada*, and presented a temptation worth fighting for. However, I consoled myself with this fact that I had left a good outfit in San Antonio for the mail of August 9, and that furthermore I had then with me a strong party of men, sufficient, in my opinion, to guard the relays and property under my charge. I had time to consider as to my course before passing Fort Clarke. Commending my discomfited conductor to a surgeon at once, and promising to send such instructions from Fort Clarke as were rendered necessary by his loss, we went on our way.

Our route to-day has been over an excellent road passing through a country adapted to grazing, or capable of being cultivated to advantage, in seasons when rain enough falls to insure a crop. We camped at midnight five miles this side of "Uvalde." Made a distance of 58 miles to-day.

August 3.—Left our camp at 5 a. m. During the morning we passed a government train under charge of Captain John E. Pope, topographical engineers. Captain Pope is *en route* for the Llano Estacado, near the 32d parallel of latitude, to experiment as to the practicability of procuring water there by means of artesian wells.

[When I returned over this portion of our road in January, I found that Captain Pope was at his camp near the mouth of Delaware creek. I consider it an excellent thing for this section of country that our government should undertake to establish or disprove the opinions expressed by many scientific men upon the question of obtaining water by means of artesian wells in the Llano Estacado of Texas, and on the high table lands of Arizona and New Mexico. I refer to this matter again in treating of the present watering places on our route, and in presenting my ideas of the proper method of securing an adequate supply of water at intermediate points.]

We cooked our breakfast this morning under the trees just outside of the tower of Uvalde. We have tin plates, tin cups, knives and forks, iron spoons, a gunny bag as a table cloth, and one seat in the shape of a water keg among eight of us. Camped for the night at 8 p. m. Made 42 miles to-day.

August 4.—Left camp at 3 a. m. Reached Fort Clarke at 5 a. m. Left Fort Clarke at 1 p. m.

I wrote to Mr. Birch to-day, informing him of my progress up to this point, calling his attention particularly to the attack on Captain Wallace, which resulted in the loss of that complete outfit. I further advised him of having drawn on him at 90 days' date for the sum of five thousand dollars, payable at the Bank of Manhattan Company, New York, at which I knew he kept his account. I requested Mr. Birch to remit this money at once from California to the cashier of the bank, as our agent at San Antonio would need money to purchase new stock with which to replace those stolen by the Indians; this letter I addressed to Sacramento, the city which would be his headquarters during his stay in California.

[Desiring to make this draft the basis of a further credit for our agent in San Antonio, I enclosed it to the firm there who had agreed to make advances to the line. I requested them to continue such advances according to promise, and further desired them to collect this draft of \$5,000, passing the same to the credit of the line on open account. In consequence of Mr. Birch's death this draft was not paid at maturity, but returned protested to Texas, and is supposed to have been in the mail on board the steamer Opelousas, which was lost in the Gulf.]

Before leaving San Antonio I procured an order, which General Twiggs gave me very cheerfully, requesting the commanders of the military posts in his division to give me an escort for the mail whenever I asked it. I did not deem it necessary at this time to ask for one, as I had with me twenty well-armed men. Under any circumstances, however, when we were required to make mail speed, this order for an escort would prove useless, inasmuch as by its terms I was required to furnish transportation to the soldiers. We could not do it and make mail time. To escort a train of supplies for us, at any time, such an order would prove very acceptable, when the speed is about one-half that of the mail.

In this same order of General Twiggs, of which I regret not having a copy, he gave us permission to place our mules in the government herd, and also to keep an hostler with them at each of the military posts.

Camped for the night, at 10½ p. m.; made 42 miles to-day. August 5. Left camp at 4.40.

Leaving Fort Clarke may be properly described as leaving the settlements for the Indian country. This fact in connexion with the recent accident to our

train made us all now doubly cautious on our day and night guards.

At noon to-day we saw Indian signs around a water hole; these signs consisted of pony tracks, unshod hoofs, and moccasin prints; they were presumed by our most most expert frontier men to be only a few hours old. Camped for the night at 8 p. m.

Made 41 miles to-day.

August 6.—Left camp at 4 a. m.

[After this day I did not note the precise hour of leaving camp in the morning, or of camping at night, because the jolting, or some other cause, had put my own watch out of order. Our hours, however, were much the same as they have been stated until passing the Tucson, west of which a large portion of the work was night service.—See Journal, [Sept. 1st](#) to 18th.]

In carrying the mail we do not drive all the time from our morning start to the night camp. We stop four times during the day; twice for our two meals of breakfast and dinner; breakfast after the morning drive, dinner about 4 o'clock. We also stop once for a nooning, and once about sunset to graze the mules, at which hour they seem to feed best.

We stopped half an hour to-day at Camp Hudson, situated at the second crossing of the San Pedro, or the Devil's river; here I found the remnant of our coach, with the pole and ten spokes broken, the bars gone, the top all stripped, a bullet hole through the body from a gun, carbine, or some piece carrying a heavy ball, and fired by the Indians. Made 42 miles to-day.

August 7.—To-day we crossed the Llano Estacado at the narrowest part. By my schedule of distances you will perceive it is only thirty miles from Howard Springs to Live Oak creek, and only a portion of the distance can be properly called the *staked plain*; in fact this is about its southern termination. Camped about midnight. Made 52 miles to-day.

August 8.—Our morning drive brought us about breakfast time just outside the lines at Fort Lancaster. I learned that Captain Skillman had purchased a pair of mules here, and gone on in good condition. We have had a fine road, with abundance of good grazing, all the way from Fort Clarke to this post. Now that we have been a number of days on our journey, we find that many of our mules are becoming foot sore or tired; these are such as are new to

the service, and they become, by the time the night drive is over, very much fatigued. Mules, with us, have to go through a period of hardening and a process of acclimation before they become adapted to the purposes of prairie staging. The speed at which we trot them, their hard work, the drinking of different kinds of water at different stopping places, all try the constitution of the animal, while even eating corn, which we feed to them at all times, whether on the road or at stations, is something to be learned. On the journey up from San Antonio to El Paso we change the limestone water of the coast for the water impregnated variously with vegetable matter, alkali, or sulphur. This change is found to affect men as well as all descriptions of stock, and mules often times give out when hard driven immediately after drinking either the waters of the Pecos or those of any of the watering places between that river and Fort Davis. Coming down the road from El Paso to San Antonio, reversing the course of this change, the water is not found to have the same effect. Took in a supply of corn, for which we paid \$2 50 per bushel. Made 28 miles, camping on the Pecos at 8 p. m.

August 9.—To-day we passed a freshly made grave which marked a spot which had recently been the scene of a battle between a party of soldiers and the Indians. I gathered the following particulars: The soldiers, under a sergeant, were escorting a mail which, previously to the letting of our contract, had been once a month transported by the quartermaster's department to and from Fort Davis and Fort Clarke. While the soldiers were at dinner, a few Indians came into their camp, under the protection of a white flag, asking for something to eat. As it turned out from their subsequent attack, this visit was a ruse to ascertain the strength of the party, as well as to form an idea of their vigilance. The soldiers treated them well, gave them some trifles, and the Indians partook of their hospitality. At parting they shook hands and went off on the road ahead, leaving the soldiers without the slightest suspicion of any danger. A few hundred yards from their camping place, as the wagon was descending a short steep hill into a gully which runs from the mountains to the Pecos, the soldiers were attacked by the Indians, and the sergeant was mortally wounded at the first fire. They retreated, fighting as well as they were able, while four of them carried the wounded sergeant; but an overwhelming number of the Indians pressed upon them so closely that, at his earnest request to save themselves and drop him, as he would only embarrass their efforts, they left the

sergeant the prey of the Indians and gathered around the wagon. They were finally compelled to abandon the property, with the result, usual in such cases, of not being followed by the Indians, who only wanted the plunder. The soldiers came into Fort Lancaster, distant about forty miles.

The policy which requires government officers to respect a white flag in the hands of Indians has led to a number of massacres on the road. The policy of the mail men is, never, under any circumstances, to allow them near us, and much less to risk the danger of having them actually in camp. They have repeatedly tried the ruse of endeavoring to approach under the protection of a piece of dirty cotton cloth tied to a spear, but we send a ball over their heads so soon as they come within rifle range, after which warning they keep aloof.

Made 44 miles to-day.

August 10.—Made 45 miles to-day, without anything having happened of particular interest.

August 11.—Camped to-night a few miles east of Fort Davis, preferring to arrive there at breakfast to-morrow morning. Our mules were suffering yesterday and to-day from the effects of drinking the sulphur waters, which mineral impregnates nearly all the springs and creeks from the Pecos to Fort Davis. We are now rapidly ascending the table land of western Texas, where copious rains have been falling for some time. The grass is abundant and excellent in quality, but rather young for working mules that are compelled to make speed. The grass, combined with the sulphur water, compelled us for a day or two to be cautious not to overwork our stock. We avoid trouble by shortening our drives.

We made only 34 miles to-day.

August 12.—At 3 a. m. this morning, accompanied by two men, I took the mail on to Fort Davis in my own light carriage, drawn by four mules, leaving the three heavy coaches and stock to come on at their leisure. Fort Davis is about 4,500 feet above the ocean; and before getting so far on my road even as this post, I had found the coaches, of which we had purchased eleven for the line, so heavy as to be unfit for the service. [The continual ascent of the roads, together with the weight the mules were compelled to haul, had fatigued them so much that I deemed it necessary to change them,

if possible. To borrow some government mules for the trip to El Paso seemed to be an excellent plan, if I could procure such a privilege. I would then leave those I had here to be used as relays for the next up mail. From the information I had obtained, I had not the least doubt but that I could purchase plenty of mules in El Paso to use in stocking the upper portion of our road. I made application to Colonel Sewall, the commanding officer at this post, who, upon reflection, decided to loan me the mules I wanted. I made an arrangement which I considered a very favorable one, and it certainly was a great advantage at the time, but it afterwards proved a prolific source of trouble to me. To sustain my application for mules, I represented to Colonel Sewall my exact position; that I was the superintendent of the road and also sole agent for the contractor; that I was engaged in stocking and putting in running order this pioneer mail. I further took the liberty of stating how great an interest your department felt in the enterprise. I proposed to leave my forty-two mules at the fort, and that he should loan me thirty-six of theirs to take our coaches to El Paso. I stated to him my plan of purchasing on the Rio Grande all the mules I needed, and that I would return his at once with the first down mail. To this arrangement he assented, sending a corporal and two men with me to take charge of the mules.

I may as well mention here that, on reaching El Paso, I found myself in a position where, in consequence of inability to purchase mules, I had either to stop the mail until I could collect them in the towns up and down the valley and over the river, or else to take some of these Fort Davis mules further on my journey. Believing myself justified, under the circumstances, in deviating my promise as to the time of returning the mules, I took fourteen of them with me to Tucson; the balance, twenty-two in number, I returned at once to Fort Davis by the corporal. Of these fourteen so taken, seven were returned to Fort Davis during the period of my stay on the Pacific, while the other seven were replaced from our own herd, by virtue of an agreement which allowed Colonel Sewall to take such of ours as he wanted, to replace any of his mules which might be missing. Colonel Sewall was so indignant at my not sending back the whole number of his mules at once, that he wrote to all the posts along our line, requesting them to refuse me any favor, alleging, as his reason, my bad faith to him. He further desired the officers to continue such refusal until the mule transaction should be settled to his satisfaction. This request gave the line

considerable trouble at Fort Fillmore, during my absence. On my return to Fort Davis I was unable to appease Colonel Sewall, though I explained to him the whole transaction, as I have endeavored to do here. He refused to order the quartermaster to withdraw his offensive letter to the posts on the line, although this was the point I particularly urged for his consideration, as injurious to our interests. I feel now, as I did at the time of taking the mules—which I did not do without reflection—that the circumstances justified my course; that the interest of the overland mail to the government was above the value even of the whole number of mules borrowed, and that, under these circumstances, I should have been forgiven for not keeping my promise.]

August 13.—Left Fort Davis at 5.40 a. m. Early this morning I met the mail from Santa Fé, and, in accordance with the agreement between Mr. Giddings and myself to incorporate our two stocks, so as to perform the tri-monthly service, I sent back a portion of my own party, with orders to return as far as Fort Clarke. One great advantage of this additional force to the party going down was the greater protection the mail would receive in passing through that portion of the Indian country so recently the scene of depredations.

Made 29 miles to-day.

August 14.—Our government mules, fresh and corn-fed, took us along at a much more rapid pace than we have been in the habit of travelling during the course of the past week.

We made 60 miles to-day.

August 15.—Our second drive to-day was for a mile or more, through a long and narrow cañon, with the mountains bordering the Rio Grande on the east. This cañon led us into the valley of the river, at a point one hundred miles below where our road leaves it in going westward. After crossing the valley, and making a camp on the banks of the river, our road to-day turns abruptly northward. We encountered a terrible thunder storm at noon, it being the first heavy rain we have had on the road. August is one of the rainy months throughout this portion of the Rio Grande valley and Sonora; we may, therefore, expect many such storms before reaching the coast range of mountains which form the climatic boundary between California and Arizona. After a thorough drenching, we started at two

o'clock, in a bright sunny afternoon, and drove slowly up the Rio Grande. Through this particular portion of the valley the rainy season is an advantage to the otherwise sandy road. Along here, animals which are fatigued from a tedious or rapid journey through Texas must be well treated or they give out. Fifty miles above here, in the neighborhood of San Eleazario, and, indeed, at all the Spanish towns along the river, the road is made much worse by the rains. The corn and wheat fields are all cultivated by irrigation, and the irrigating ditches, called *acequias*, liable to be overflowed from the rain, cross the roads in many places. Camped to-night on a slough of the river.

Made 40 miles to-day.

August 16.—The road proving so very muddy in some places, and heavy from sand in others, besides finding it was growing more and more muddy as we proceeded, I took my light four-mule carriage, with a change of animals, left all our heavy coaches and baggage, and started on with the mails. We reached the *presidio* of San Elearan at 7 p. m. to-day; there we changed our mail, and then pushed on, after dark, for Socorro, where the conductor, with his train, was waiting to take the mail through to Santa Fé. Our drive from San Elearan to Socorro was at a slow walk through mud and water all the way, caused by the recent rains overflowing the ditches. Many portions of the surrounding country were covered with water like a lake.

Made 43 miles to-day.

August 17.—Rained all night, showering during the morning. I went nineteen miles to-day, to Franklin, El Paso. The Santa Fé mail went on to its destination. The quartermaster at Fort Bliss very kindly gave me the use of his blacksmith shop in which to repair one of my wagons, by which timely aid I was enabled to place it in a pretty decent condition for service. Looked about me for mules to complete my outfit for the Pimos villages, but much to my disappointment could find none suited to our service. Mules are scarce at El Paso.

August 18.—Another rainy day, with occasional sunshine. Found an abundance of very excellent fruit at El Paso: pears, peaches, and particularly grapes. The heavy train came in to-day.

August 19.—A beautiful day; I find some difficulty in purchasing the required corn for my mules. Last year the corn crop of this valley was a partial failure, in consequence of which the corn at present in use here is brought from Chihuahua; I pay equal to about \$2 50 per bushel. I find it impossible to purchase mules and get them here in season to be of use for the next mail going west, due here on the 21st or 22d. To insure that the next mail shall go forward with despatch, I deemed it best to-day to send the train up the river with directions to proceed as far as Fort Fillmore, 50 miles above El Paso, there to await the coming mail. Our mules need shoeing, and some other preparations are required for the journey. I have bought all the mules I could find, and lastly borrowed fourteen from the herd of government mules which I brought from Fort Davis. The others I returned in charge of the corporal who came up with me, (see journal, [August 2.](#)) I purchased to-day a pair of large Missouri mules, and at once sent my small wagon and nine mules down to the Presidio, 25 miles below El Paso, with directions to receive the up mail there, and bring it with all speed to Fort Fillmore; this I planned to save time.

August 20.—Was engaged all day in preparing the way, as far as possible, to have the business of the line run smoothly during my absence, I stored my two heavy coaches to wait the chances of the future.

August 21.—Early this afternoon an express came in from Captain Holliday, who was *en route* to Fort Fillmore, for the purposes stated under date of August 19. He wrote me that his wagon had broken down, with the further prospect of being scarcely able to reach the post with it. I immediately purchased a private carriage, the only one in El Paso any way suited to our purpose. By the kindness of Colonel Reeves, commanding Fort Bliss, who loaned me a team, I was enabled to despatch the carriage for Fort Fillmore this evening. I had no mules at Franklin with which to send it up. At 10 p.m. the mail and Mr. Giddings came in from San Antonio, having left there August 9, the contract day. Our coach arrived here with a broken pole which is by no means a small obstacle in this remote country, particularly when the accident chances to happen after dark and no other carriage is to be obtained, while the mail must go on. By splicing we made it answer our present purpose, though consuming nearly all night in preparations.

August 22.—Left El Paso at three o'clock, a. m., and found the roads heavy all the way along the river. Succeeded in reaching Fort Fillmore at six o'clock, p. m., after a day's work of forty-two miles. I found the train encamped ready for departure, only waiting my arrival with the mail. We examined the Rio Grande to-night, preparatory to crossing; found the river not fordable, and also found there would be too much risk in attempting to ferry over in the night; thus we are unwillingly compelled to remain encamped on the east bank until to-morrow morning. Another source of trouble was my carriages; I found that neither of those I now had were fit to go on the road. Those we had originally purchased, two of which I brought up with me, were too heavy for the mules, while the two I now had were not strong enough to carry the required loads. In this dilemma I despatched two men to Las Cruces, six miles above Fort Fillmore, giving them orders to purchase at any fair price, if suited to our purpose, a second-hand carriage which we heard was there for sale. My messengers returned about two o'clock in the morning with an old ambulance, which answered a good purpose all the way to San Diego. By setting the axletrees of one of my other carriages I thought to secure two, which would answer a temporary purpose. Made 44 miles to-day.

August 23.—We commenced crossing the river at about sunrise. Our method was this: we placed all our baggage and mails in skiffs, and ferrying them over in the first place, then swam our mules, and lastly the carriages were crossed, by placing the wheels of one side of the carriage on one skiff, and those of the other side in another skiff, and poling them along; on reaching the other side we pulled the carriage up the steep bank by man power.

At the town of Mesilla, which is situated some four miles from the ferry, I had to purchase yet another carriage in place of one of mine, the axeltrees of which proved entirely too light. This made four carriages I had purchased since arriving in the Rio Grande valley, before getting two which were even temporarily fit for carrying the mail. We finally got away from Mesilla at 11 o'clock, a. m. In consequence of the muddy state of the roads across the valley, which was here one continuous cornfield for some half dozen miles, we made very slow progress. The *Mesa*, so called, rises very abruptly after you cross the valley, and we pass to the left of this *Mesa* through some one of its numerous cañons or gorges. The only road accessible at this time to

wagons was so dimly defined that we missed our way and consumed all of the afternoon in trying to get to the top of the *Mesa*, and ended in being compelled to return to the village of "Pechacio," where we passed the night. Made 8 miles to-day.

August 24.—Left Pechacio village at daylight, this time with another guide; reached the top of the *Mesa* through a cañon and road some three miles long. We are now crossing the *jornada* of 65 miles, between La Mesilla and Cook's wells. We found the road somewhat muddy, the result of the recent rains. We had a fearful thunder storm at noon to-day, and in about half an hour every one was wet through to the skin; afterwards the sun came out warm and pleasant and dried us to a cheerful temperature again. To-day our conductor, Captain Holliday, who is an experienced voyageur on the plains, discovered a natural tank in the rocks. He was first attracted to it by noticing a pair of doves which flew over his head and alighted there. [This tank held enough to water all of our mules, and on my return trip in November, I learned that the same conductor had found water enough for his mules every trip during the intermediate period. I state this incident as one illustrative of the probable chances of finding places adapted to natural tanks. Doves and a species of small sparrow are said to be sure signs of water.]

Camped at 8½ p. m., making 48 miles to-day.

August 25.—Started at daylight this morning, and breakfasted at Cook's spring, in a drizzling rain, which lasted at intervals all day. This spring is at the foot of the eastern slope of the Sierra Madre mountains. By examining the table of distances, it will be noticed that the Rio Mimbres is eighteen miles westward from Cook's spring. We breakfasted at Cook's spring, and dined several miles west of the Mimbres. This speed made over the mountains will, I think, convey a good idea of what must be the nature of our roads through the Sierra Madre. Passed the Rio Mimbres just before dinner; we had to be very cautious in crossing, else the force of the current would have upset our carriages; the stream was so much of a flood that we had to have one of the men plunge into the water and hold up the lead mules by a rope fastened to their heads. The force of the current and depth of water took them off their feet for a distance of a few yards. A few weeks later, one of our mail trains going west was camped two days on the eastern camp of the Mimbres, unable to cross. We stopped at Cow spring for a

couple of hours, about sunset, to graze our animals; camped for the night at the mouth of a cañon leading up to the Burre mountains; camped at 10 o'clock 30 minutes, making fifty-five miles to-day.

August 26.—Started at daylight. About 8 o'clock this morning, coming down through one of the many cañons leading from the Burre mountains, we found the mail coach which Captain Skillman had taken from San Antonio standing in our road. My first thought was, that another train had been cut off by the Indians, but an examination soon showed the nature of the accident; one of the hind wheels had evidently crushed down, and the two forward ones were gone. The wagon stood propped up carefully in the middle of the road. We concluded that Capt. Skillman had gone on with his two forward wheels, making what travellers term a "cache" among the surrounding rocks of all his spare articles. This we afterwards found to be the case. We stopped here only about as long as it takes to write the fact, then rolled away over the plaza on our journey. About sunset, we had a small sample of what might be suffered for want of water, if men were ignorant of the road. We had brought water from where we breakfasted to answer for our dinner uses, but the day had been very warm, and all of us had drunk very freely, until our canteens had become low. We were deceived by some wagon tracks into turning off from the main road, losing considerable time in finding our way back again, both men and mules being very thirsty. We found water in wagon ruts and holes in the ground. Down went men on the ground, mules and men both drinking in the same manner from the same holes. More accurate information as to distances, and the consequent preparation we now make for any portion of our journey, where we know there is a long stretch without water, does away with any danger from thirst, so far as the men and passengers are concerned; the mules sometimes have to go all day without water. Camped at 11 o'clock.

Made 43 miles to-day.

August 27.—Off at 5.30 a. m. Crossed the Saur river this morning; found it quite a stream, and the land swampy on both sides, with plenty of water at the crossing. I had a splendid shot at a fine flock of wild ducks. At 4 p. m. we camped for dinner in the Chiracahui mountains at what is termed Apache Spring. Here we met the train of Paymaster Major Brice, *en route* for Fort Bliss. He had been paying off the troops at Fort Buchanan.

Showery this afternoon. About noon we saw the tracks of Captain Skillman's two wheels; he was returning eastward; he took a different road from the one we came. I regretted missing him. This pass through the Chiracahui mountains is the most tedious of any we have on our road through Arizona, though this is only slow by comparison with the pass through the Sierra Madre. Though slow, the road is excellent, excepting for a short distance and the climbing of a number of steep hills.

From the Rio Saur to Dos Cabezas Spring is thirty-two miles. We made this in seven hours driving time. We breakfasted at the Saur; made two camps in the distance, making our last drive for the day after we had passed Dos Cabezas spring. Camped at 12 o'clock, midnight. Made 47 miles to-day.

August 28.—Harnessed at 5.45 a. m. To-day we left the main travelled road, now in use by the troops, and by trains of supplies *en route* to Fort Buchanan. This road turns southward before coming to the San Pedro river, crossing that stream higher up than we do. The main road is in nearly a due west course till we reach the river; then we turn northward six miles before coming to the ford. This cut-off is not so well defined as the road we had been travelling. Our route lies through Tucson, to which place there has been but little direct trade; and as this was only the second mail coach which has come over the road, we found the way by no means very clearly marked out. We did not deem it prudent to cross the San Pedro river to-night, as the recent rains had swollen it to a much higher point than usual. Camped for the night on the eastern branch of the San Pedro at 11.15 p. m. Made 42 miles to-day.

August 29.—Crossed the San Pedro as soon as it was light enough to see. About 10 o'clock this morning, as we were making our second drive for the day, I saw a party approaching us mounted on mules. Rode forward to meet them. They proved to be the mail party from San Diego, who left there 9th August with an outfit of saddle mules and pack animals. Our agent had reached San Diego with men and supplies on the 21st of July, in ample time to have started the mail of the 24th, if he could have procured animals.—(See Journal of June 20.) This mail had been twenty days in coming from San Diego to our place of meeting, forty miles east of Tucson. Our mail had been twenty days coming twice the distance. I had sent positive orders in my letters, per steamer of 20th June, to San Francisco, that the mail should be started in a coach, if possible, but that at all events it was only to be sent

as far east as the Pimos villages.—(See Journal of [July 24](#).) Mr. Birch had deemed it best in San Francisco to alter this plan, and ordered complete outfits to be sent from San Diego, to go through to San Antonio. I ordered this mail party back, to return with me to Tucson, as nothing was to be gained by their continuing on. At 8 o'clock I mounted my mule, and went on to Tucson with two men. We reached there at 2 o'clock in the morning. My purpose in hastening on in advance of the train was to lose no time, but to purchase mules at once, with which to proceed to San Diego with the through mail. I wished also, if possible, to buy some description of vehicle, in which to send the mail back to El Paso. Train camped in a drizzling rain at 11 o'clock.

Made 49 miles to-day.

August 30.—Commenced operations at daylight. I found here Mr. Tivey, formerly of Texas, a surveyor from California, who was *en route* for Santa Fé. He had with him a wagon which would suit our purpose, also a dozen of good mules; he had been waiting some weeks for company. I made an arrangement with this gentleman by which he loaned the mail party his outfit, and agreed to accompany them to La Mesilla. This he did, partly for the consideration of protection, but principally from public spirit and a desire to see the new mail line go into operation at once; besides, having been an extensive traveller himself in new countries, he had a good idea of the obstacles to be overcome in our early organization. The wagon and mules belonging to Mr. Tivey, added to those mules I had brought on which were in condition to return, made a respectable outfit to use in sending the mail back to El Paso. I made up another outfit for myself by taking the inferior of the two carriages I had brought from La Mesilla, purchasing seven mules, and selecting five more from among those belonging to the San Diego party, whom I had turned back. To aid me in taking the mail through to its destination, a distance of 469 miles, I took two Americans and a Mexican, making four of us in the party, as we should soon be beyond the point where the Apaches are in the practice of roaming, and, therefore, so strong a party as came from La Mesilla to Tucson would be unnecessary. For the first time since coming on to the road I took command of the mail party. To make the needed connexion here between the eastern and western divisions of our road, I made two arrangements of mail parties. I detailed two men to come on slowly to the Pimos villages, with instructions to await

there the next mail from San Antonio. On receiving the mail they were to push on with all speed for Yuma, 180 miles from Pimos, where I would leave further instructions.

I took with me two other men, whom I also proposed leaving at the Pimos under instruction to return to Tucson with the next mail going east, which mail would have left San Diego August 24. At Tucson they were to deliver the mail to the present train, which would wait as long as possible. Got away about noon, and in the night met with a disagreeable accident: the perch of our carriage broke. We spliced it with mezquit branches and ropes, but, in the first gully we went through, we broke down again even worse than before. This second accident happened at 2 o'clock in the morning; our carriage was a complete wreck, but in any view of the case it was apparently best to camp until daylight; we could then see whether the damages could be repaired or the carriage would have to be abandoned. Camped about 3 o'clock in the morning. Made 36 miles since leaving Tucson.

August 31.—At daylight we commenced repairing damages. I found that by taking out one of the standards to the top of the carriage, and wrapping that and a piece of broken whiffle tree tightly with raw hides soaked soft in water, the coach promised well for a temporary purpose with a light weight. To lighten us I left on the road our agent for the Pimos station whom I had with me, also the two men who were to return to Tucson with the mail. I then proceeded on my journey towards San Diego. Camped about 12 o'clock on the banks of the Gila river. Made 40 miles to-day.

September 1.—Off at daylight this morning; reached the first village of the Pimos about sunrise, and there I bought the corn necessary for our mules, a little wheat for same purpose, and a few beans, also a pair of chickens. (Wheat should be fed sparingly, and soaked before using.) Our barter consisted of cotton cloth and a few bells, both of which I purchased in Tucson. Camped for breakfast at the Maricopa wells, which we have since selected as the site for our station; remained at the wells until 3 p. m. waiting for our agent to come up whom I yesterday left behind on the road. Finally he came along, and we prepared for a start. While camping at the wells I was witness to the largest Indian battle of the times. The Yuma Indians, aided by the Mojaves and Tonto Apaches as their allies, attacked the Maricopas just before daylight this morning. The Maricopas and Pimos

are allied strongly together. The former being comparatively few in numbers, are rather under the protection of the more numerous Pimos. The Maricopas are the more western of the two tribes, and as the Yumas approached from down the river, their villages were consequently the first attacked. Some warriors and their families were killed, and their huts fired before the presence of the Yumas was known. We saw the huts blazing and thought they were signal fires. Besides warriors on foot, every Indian that could get a horse was in the fight, many of them going a half dozen miles to reach the battle ground. One aged chief, whose wife had been killed by the Yumas, rode furiously up to our camp, foaming at the mouth, and begged of us in good Spanish to aid them against the Yumas; of course we declined. When the battle was over he refused to speak or understand a word of Spanish.

The principal fight was along the bank of the Gila, not half a mile from our camp. One hundred and four Yumas left their villages at the junction of the Gila and Colorado, led on by a young and ambitious chief, whose new dignity required some striking act to dazzle his people. He and ninety-three of his warriors were killed within an half hour, on the side of a hill in plain view from the spot where I was reclining under a tree.

At this place the river makes what is termed "the big bend" of the Gila; the road lies nearly due east and west, while the river makes a horse shoe, probably four times as long as the distance from the Maricopa to Tazotal, at which place the road touches the river again. By the schedule of distances you will perceive it is forty miles from Maricopa to Tazotal.

We started from Maricopa Wells at 3 p. m. and drove all night, reaching Tazotal for our breakfast camp a little after sunrise.

Made 69 miles to-day.

September 2.—After breakfast this morning we made a drive of ten miles, and then lay by to avoid travelling during the hottest part of the day. The four of us take turns in sleeping and herding mules. Fed our animals on the Mesquit beans, of which there is a great abundance along the Gila river. Started from camp at 3 o'clock p. m.; about sunset met the mail party of August 24, from San Diego, equipped in the same excellent manner for the service as the party of August 9. The train I had come on with from El Paso, together with the addition made by Mr. Tivey, was waiting at Tucson for

this mail; to expedite its progress, I had brought two men to the Maricopa station to take it back to Tucson, (see journal of [August 30](#),) but I had also left orders with these men not to wait any longer than sunset to-night, as the conductor and train must return to La Mesilla at once to be in time to bring westward, from El Paso to Tucson, the mail of September 9, from San Antonio. In view of these orders, together with the certainty of not being able to make the connexion at Tucson, I turned this party back to Fort Yuma. I gave instructions to the conductor of this mail to equip himself and two men for a light service of three days' duration, and to be in readiness to take the next mail, namely, that of September 9, from San Diego, and carry it with all possible speed to Maricopa station, at which place the carriage, or an escort for Tucson, would thereafter be waiting to receive it. We drove until 10 p. m., then camped on the banks of the Gila, waiting for the moon to rise before attempting to cross. Moon rose nearly full, and at about 12 o'clock we crossed and recrossed the Gila, leaving ourselves on the southern bank from which we started. Drove until about three o'clock in the morning.

Made 40 miles to-day.

September 3.—Started at daylight. Camped about four hours at noon to rest ourselves and animals. Started at four o'clock, and drove till dark. Started again at ten o'clock, p. m., and drove till two o'clock in the morning.

Made 56 miles to-day.

September 4.—Off at daylight; we should have made a good morning drive, but our carriage stuck in a mud hole, and we had to lighten it by stripping and wading in; even then we hauled it out with difficulty. It had been raining on the Gila during the past few weeks, and the road in many places is gullied, while mud holes are common, and I noticed considerable standing water. We reached Colorado city, opposite Fort Yuma, at 11 o'clock p. m., here we changed a few of our mules, took the mail for San Diego from the quartermaster, and repaired our coach with additions of leather and raw hide. These operations consumed the balance of the night, and it was daylight when we hitched up for a start.

Made 49 miles to-day.

September 5.—Crossed the Colorado about sunrise over an excellent ferry, then drove to Cook's Wells to breakfast, 20 miles. We remained encamped at Cook's Wells to rest ourselves and animals till nearly sunset, and then started to cross what is considered the worst portion of the Colorado desert, namely, a distance of twenty-two miles through heavy sand from Cook's Wells to Alamo Mucho. This journey consumed the night. We reached the Alamo Mucho wells at daylight.

Made 42 miles to-day.

September 6.—To-day we pushed all day long to get over the desert, and reached Indian Wells about sunset, twenty-two miles from Alamo Mucho; our road was much better than that of last night. Here we expected to find water for ourselves and stock, but an encampment of Yuma Indians had used it nearly all up, and we could only procure enough for our own dinner; none was to be had for the mules, so we tried to console them with a feed of corn. The want of water left us no resource but to push on for Carissa creek, thirty-two miles more. We travelled all night and reached Carissa creek about sunrise in the morning. This portion of the road is by no means a bad one.

Made 52 miles to-day.

September 7.—We found our fourteen animals were now very much fatigued. They have had no sleep from Fort Yuma to Carissa, while many of them have come with me all the way from Tucson in less than eight days; they had had no water for twenty-four hours, that is, from Alamo Mucho to this place, Carissa; here they filled themselves at once with the medicated waters of the creek, and thus destroyed their appetites, so that they would not eat a proper quantity of hay or grain. At 9 o'clock, when we left, they were very tired, sleepy, and unwilling to go. Under these circumstances, I decided to select the best animals from among our *mulada*, and push on over the coast range of mountains to San Diego with the mail, taking only one man with me; the coach would come the longer road, by way of San Ysabel. I put this decision in execution about 9 o'clock in the morning, and reached Vallecita at 2 p. m., where we procured something to eat, but could get none of the Indians to guide us over the mountains, as I had confidently calculated upon being able to do. There was no resource left us but to push on alone; so, taking minute directions where to find the best trail, we

recommenced our journey, expecting to climb the mountains in time to reach Lassator's ranch, in one of the valleys, by or before sunset. Our tired animals proved unequal to the required speed, so that after climbing the steep mule path which led up the mountain for several miles, we camped on our trail, in the middle of a splendid table land covered with pine trees, situated near the top of the mountains.

The moon came up about 11 o'clock, giving enough light for us to keep the trail; once we chased a star for a mile, thinking it was a light in a hut; finally reaching the ranch without accident, or much detention on the way, at 2 o'clock in the morning. Tried to procure horses at once to proceed on to San Diego, but the animals were all turned out in the valley grazing and could not be had before morning. We reluctantly went to bed; and, once in the hay-stack, we slept soundly till daylight.

Made 36 miles to-day.

September 8.—At 9 o'clock a. m. we left Lassator's ranch with fresh animals, this time mounted on horses. After a toilsome day's journey down the mountains, we reached San Diego at 10 o'clock p. m., bringing the first through mail which had reached here in schedule time. I had come myself from San Antonio to San Diego in thirty-eight days.

September 9.—This morning I despatched the mail from San Diego in charge of two men, with directions to deliver it at Fort Yuma to the party I had left there, who would in turn carry it to the Pimos villages at Maricopa station, or at Tucson, where a coach would be in readiness to carry it on to La Mesilla, at which last place a second coach would carry it to the Presidio of San Eleazario. Each of these parties going east, after delivering their mail, were under instructions to wait and bring back a return mail over that portion of the road allotted to them. [These were the arrangements I had made *en route*, and up to this date they have insured the prompt delivery of the mails at each end of our line.]

When Mr. Birch and myself parted in New York, on the 23d of June, we made an arrangement to meet in San Diego as soon as I could get there; I would then have travelled across the continent, and thus be able to report understandingly about the route, with estimates of expenditures made up to that time, obligations incurred, and promises given. Together we could then estimate for the future, and Mr. Birch was to give me, in San Diego, all the

money I needed in retracing my steps to San Antonio, at which latter place he would again meet me on my return. With this understanding, I had promised all along the line, to whomsoever should aid us, that I would return from California with the coin to pay up all obligations. Mr. Giddings also made use of this promise for me during my absence. Under my understanding of this agreement, I was not only very much surprised but embarrassed, on reaching San Diego, to hear of Mr. Birch's departure from San Francisco per mail steamer of August 20. Neither did I find here any advices as to his movements; furthermore, the coast steamer had left for San Francisco on the 6th, two days before my arrival, and would not be here to leave again until the 21st. Thus I was compelled to entire inaction towards placing the Pacific end of our line in good condition until I could send to San Francisco for coaches, harness, provisions, general equipment, and money. My time, from the 9th to the 21st, appeared to be nearly or quite useless to the line, except in scouring the country for mules, which proved to be not particularly plenty in that section of California.

[Had not Mr. Birch been lost in the Central America September 11, no trouble would have arisen from his not having met me according to agreement. He could have explained everything satisfactorily, and shown, in my opinion, that he had otherwise planned well for the maintenance of our credit.]

September 13.—To-day I despatched a party of our men with a wagon and saddle mules, under instructions to examine very carefully the mountain passes eastward of San Diego, that we might find, if possible, a better and shorter route for a road than the present circuitous one by way San Ysabel. The county surveyor very kindly accompanied our party, giving us the benefit of his experience; so also did one of the county supervisors, thus showing the great interest which the citizens of San Diego felt in the success of an overland mail. [Our party returned on the 18th, reporting having found a trail which, in their opinion, could be made an excellent road with a moderate outlay of labor.]

September 21.—To-day I despatched a messenger to San Francisco by the steamer, with instructions to make, as far as possible, all needful purchases of supplies for the western end of the line, and to bring them to San Diego by return steamer. I leave at the earliest possible moment to retrace my steps over the road, as I had promised to be back about October.

September 24.—I contracted to-day for hay and straw to supply stations we had made on the desert, at Vallecita and Carissa creeks.

September 29.—To-day I despatched a train, consisting of a coach and wagon, destined for our mail station at Maricopa wells; they were loaded with rations for the men who remain there permanently.

October 4.—Despatched a relay of ten mules over the mountains to meet and accompany the train of September 29.

October 6.—Steamer arrived from San Francisco this morning, having on board for us all the supplies our agent had been able to obtain. Commenced at once preparing for my return trip.

October 17.—To-day I despatched two coaches, with complete outfits of animals and other necessities. One of the coaches is to run between Carissa creek and Fort Yuma; the other is to run between Fort Yuma and Maricopa wells. I despatched these coaches to-day in order to have them at their stations in readiness to take through any passengers for Arizona or San Antonio which might come from San Francisco by steamer of the 18th. We had advertised in the California papers that we were ready for passengers as follows:

Office of the San Antonio and San Diego Mail Line.—This line is now ready to ticket passengers through from San Francisco to New Orleans, *via* San Diego, Fort Yuma, Tucson, Mesilla, Fort Filmore, El Paso, and San Antonio, as well as to all intermediate stations. Also to Santa Fé and Albuquerque, (New Mexico.) For rates of passage, and further information, apply at the office of the company, Kearny street, (opposite Plaza.)

C. McLAUGHIN, *Agent.*

R. E. DOYLE,

Superintendent Western Division.

October 22.—This morning I despatched two more coaches and fourteen animals heavily laden with every description of supplies for the line. They go round to Carissa creek by the road, while I shall take the shorter mountain trail to-morrow.

October 23.—Left San Diego on horseback this morning, accompanied by Mr. Doyle and one of my through passengers, of whom I had several.

October 25.—Passed the day in the mountains at our corral, branding a mulada of seventy-five animals, which I had purchased for the line.

October 27.—Reached Carissa creek, the place of rendezvous, early this afternoon, with our *mulada*; found the coaches waiting. My party now consisted of twelve men, with three coaches, seventy-two animals, and everything necessary for our stage purposes. Our progress to Fort Yuma was slow. We left Carissa creek the 28th October and reached the fort November 2d; the delay arose from the fact that fifty-nine of our animals strayed away, detaining us two days in finding them in the desert.

November 5.—To-day the mail came in from the east, bringing to me the melancholy news of Mr. Birch's death. This intelligence very naturally alarmed the parties at Colorado city, who had been furnishing our men with supplies. Feeling myself perfectly sure that Mr. Birch's death would have no influence in disarranging the affairs of the line, I assured the parties of my determination to continue, as I had planned, to San Antonio, and to see that the business was properly cared for. Mr. Doyle, who had accompanied me thus far from San Diego, joined with me in assuring our creditors here that we would both continue in as vigorous a superintendence as ever of the interests of the mail.

The Steamer General Jesup came up the river to-day with a cargo for the quartermaster at the post. This steamer is one of two boats owned by Johnson & Co., who are the government contractors for transporting all supplies from the mouth of the river to Fort Yuma. This boat would be a credit to her owners and builders by comparison with steamboats anywhere.

November 7.—Left Fort Yuma to-day; had with me two of the coaches with which I originally started, loaded with supplies; I had also seventy-nine of the mules. Left coach and relays at the fort.

November 9.—To-day we left Peterman's station, (on the bank of the Gila,) consisting of a log house and excellent corral, built since I passed here. Peterman told me he had built this station, which he intended making his permanent residence, in order to obtain the business of the mail line. I purchased of him several tons of mezquit beans, besides contracting for a supply of hay.

The soil in this neighborhood is excellent. Already this enterprising pioneer has contracted with a party of Mexicans to build a main irrigating ditch from the Gila, with branches sufficient to enable him to cultivate several hundred acres of land. The Mexicans are now at work. I made such arrangements for him, by writing to an agent at Fort Yuma, as would secure the necessary barley for seed, making at same time a conditional purchase of all his crop. He felt confident of gathering a good harvest the present season. Peterman originally came up here from Fort Yuma to execute a contract for several tons of mezquit beans, made with the parties who are contractors for hauling the ore of the Arizona Copper Mining Company to Fort Yuma. From the fort this copper ore is carried by steamer to the mouth of the Colorado river; thence by sailing vessel to San Francisco.

Had conversations with two other men to-day, who said they were half determined to open stations on the Gila for our accommodation; they anticipated also the chance of selling supplies to emigrants, and trading for cattle.

November 11.—Came this morning to the ford where the road usually crosses the Gila. One of our men stripped and swam across the river. I could see plainly that the current was too swift and the volume of water too great to justify the risk of attempting to cross our coaches without unloading them. We preferred making a long detour over the hills rather than attempt fording. The bottom of the river at these fords is a sort of quicksand, likely to prove troublesome when the river is swollen by rains, as it is now.

November 12.—Came to the other ford of the Gila at Oatman flat, but preferred not to attempt to cross.

November 13.—To-day we were on the *jornada* between Tezotal and Maricopa station; found plenty of water, the rains having been recent and very heavy.

November 14.—Beached our station at the Maricopa Wells to-night, after getting bogged in the mud and having to send to the station for assistance. No one could see the road, for the night was very dark. The sagacious instinct of my mule here did me good service. Giving her the reins, she took me through mud holes, around pools of water, on the road direct to the station, where she remembered having been fed with corn a few weeks before.

At the station to-night we numbered so large a party that many of us had to sleep out of doors; what with mail men waiting to go to Tucson, mail men waiting to return to Fort Yuma, Maricopa agent, our herdsman, three passengers for Tucson, seven through passengers, cook, and one or two travellers who always make our station their stopping place, added to my own party, and all of us particularly well armed, we felt ourselves to be rather formidable enemies to the Apaches.

November 15.—Quite a change has taken place since my passing here on the 1st of September. At that time I left two men, with two mules and accoutrements, a few rations, a little cotton cloth, and a few beads for barter, also a little money. Now I found a comfortable house built by putting upright poles in the ground, thatching them with tules, and covering the sides with the same. The agent had also put up a decent brush corral in which to keep our animals safe at night, for we are liable here to inroads from the Tonte Apaches.

Had a conference to-day with the Indians, who had been for a number of weeks around our post enquiring anxiously for my coming. They now squatted to have a smoke and get some presents. They informed me through an interpreter, who spoke very decent Spanish, that all the grass and the water and the land around us belonged to their tribe; that I must pay them for protecting as well as for feeding all of the many mules they saw grazing about there daily, which they found it convenient to consider as mine personally. I had promised them, when going west, that on my way back we would have this talk, and as far as possible prepared myself for them at San Diego. I gave such of them special presents as had particularly aided our agents during my absence. I fed the principal, gave all the warriors plugs of tobacco, beads, and cotton cloth, and presented the head chief and interpreter with suitable presents of shirts and fancy colored handkerchiefs. About sunset, finding that the talking, smoking, and feeding was over, and realizing the certainty of procuring no more presents to-day, the Indians shook hands with us and went off. Such of them as had horses rode them bare back, but the bulk of the warriors were footmen.

November 16.—Left the Maricopa station, on our way to Tucson, with three coaches, forty-nine animals, and twelve men. To-day met the mail of October 24 from San Antonio.

November 17.—Reached Tucson at 11½ p.m. Found train from La Mesilla waiting for the mail.

November 19.—Started from Tucson with three coaches, forty-six animals, and sixteen men, including our passengers. I also had in charge the mail of November 9 from San Diego, for which I had waited at our Maricopa station. I was now retracing my steps to La Mesilla, through the same country I had passed over in August, and, with a few unimportant variations, by nearly the same road. Then it was the rainy season, with showers almost every day; now it was the commencement of winter, with occasional northers. On both trips I found the gramma grass excellent in quality and abundant in quantity. There is plenty of water for our purposes, with wood enough for cooking, and comfortable sleeping on the ground in our blankets.

November 24.—I met Mr. Hutton at Ojo La Vaca; he is engineer of the El Paso and Fort Yuma wagon road expedition, and was examining the country very carefully to select the best line for a road, and was progressing finely.

November 25.—Met the mail coach going west with the mail of November 9, from San Antonio; also passed to-day the working party of Colonel Leach's expedition, who were building a road up the cañon, from the valley of the Rio Grande to the top of the Mesa.

November 26.—Reached Mesilla at 10 a. m., and immediately despatched the mail for San Diego by a messenger in waiting to carry it to Buchanan, one hundred miles below the Mesilla, where the train was waiting to carry it on to San Antonio. We have stocked this one hundred miles along the Rio Grande valley chiefly with horses; when we have a light mail we can express it through. I remained in the valley of the Rio Grande, passing to and fro in the course of business, from November 26 until December 24.

During my absence in California, Mr. Giddings had done every thing possible for the line; I must say he could not have done more if he had been an owner. Furthermore, I am satisfied that few men could have done so well for us. At his agency in El Paso he came in contact with the mail men, who were running from San Antonio to that place, and did much to place things in order which had been neglected at San Antonio. On leaving Mr. Giddings I had promised him, upon the faith of the understanding that Mr. Birch was to meet me at San Diego, that I would bring back with me the cash

necessary to pay up all claims against the line; but, as before explained, Mr. Birch did not meet me, I could not reach the supplies of money required, and was consequently compelled to return to the Rio Grande empty handed, relying on selling my drafts to cancel large amounts due to creditors in the valley. When I crossed the Rio Grande going west, on the 23d of August, I had twenty-four mules and two poor carriages; fourteen of these twenty-four animals belonged to Fort Davis.—(See journal, [August 12](#).) When I recrossed the same river, November 27, coming east, I had left behind me quite a different state of things.

The mail line had now nearly or quite two hundred head of mules west of the Rio Grande, stationed at San Diego, Carissa creek, Fort Yuma, Peterman's, Maricopa wells, Tucson, and La Mesilla. At each of these places agencies or stations had been established, with abundant supplies of grain everywhere. We feed corn to all our working mules. I had made contracts for hay wherever the grass was likely to be short the coming winter. We had thirty-five mail carriers and agents along this part of the line; all well-armed border-men, carefully selected for their familiarity with this kind of service. We had seven coaches on the road, and three more building in San Diego, so that we could already take passengers through from ocean to ocean in stage coaches. I felt that I had carried out in spirit the agreement with your department to place a creditable service on the line, besides having complied with the letter of the contract in carrying the mail.

I was met here in the valley by unexpected difficulties, which should not have been thrown in the way of the line.

The following advertisement was put in the San Antonio papers and came to El Paso about the time of my arrival:

SAN ANTONIO, *November 20, 1857.*

Whereas Julia A. B. Birch, of Swansea, in the county of Bristol and Commonwealth of Massachusetts, administratrix of the estate of James E. Birch, of the town and Commonwealth aforesaid, has sold, assigned, transferred, conveyed, and set over unto Oltes H. Kelton, of Charleston, South Carolina, for a good and sufficient consideration, all the stock of the mail lines and post routes from San Antonio; Texas, to San Diego, California,

and from El Paso to Santa Fé, in Texas, so far as the said James E. Birch, deceased, has any interest in the same; and whereas the said Oltes H. Kelton has appointed the undersigned his agent and attorney, by power of attorney duly acknowledged, to take charge of and superintend his entire interest in said routes, as his sole agent: Now, this is to notify all whom it may concern, that all contracts and acts made by any person otherwise than those that I may appoint, touching the interest of said routes, will be treated as a nullity.

ABNER BARROWS.

[Mr. Giddings also received a letter from Mr. Barrows, stating that Mr. Kelton had appointed him as sole agent in Texas, at the same time requesting Mr. G. to continue in charge of the line at El Paso, sending the mail forward to California as he had been doing under my superintendence. This was an awkward dilemma. It seemed clear to myself and friends that if I gave up my situation of superintendent the line must stop. If I once discarded the charge, the property would be seized by the creditors. Wages were due to the men, and accounts had been made with merchants for advances of every kind. A line through remote settlements must have a good credit. In this aspect of things, having received no letters from Mrs. Birch nor any of her friends, and no revocation of my authority having reached me, I applied to Simeon Hart, esq., of El Paso, to advance me the necessary funds to carry on the line until I could reach New York. I exhibited to Mr. Hart my original authority from Mr. Birch, together with all the subsequent facts since his death, so far as I knew them. I consider that we are indebted to Mr. Hart for the present existence of the line. He went in person to the different merchants whom we owed for advances, recommended them to take my drafts on New York, stating that he had examined the matter and was perfectly satisfied. Mr. Hart himself did more: he loaned the line ten thousand dollars, which enabled me to not only pay up the more pressing claims of the mens' wages, but all the outstanding obligations of the line, excepting the drafts before referred to on New York, and the amount due to Mr. Giddings. When I turned my back on the Rio Grande valley, the credit of the line stood well. I felt satisfied that I had done right; I am now more than satisfied.]

El Paso, December 24.—The mail of December 9 came in from San Diego at 10 a. m.

Presidio, San Eleazario, December 25.—Mail from San Antonio came in at 1 a. m. I reached our lower station on the Rio Grande, a new place which we have named Birchville, at 8 p.m.; I was *en route* for San Antonio. Here I found that the up mail of December 9 had been caught in a snow storm west of Fort Davis. Five mules had been chilled so they were unable to go on with the train. The conductor was compelled to leave the coach and nearly all the mules at Fort Davis, coming on to Birchville with six mules only, bringing the letter mail. He was most fortunate in being able to borrow a buggy for this purpose. The conductor who brought up this mail of December 9 should have returned at once to San Antonio with the down mail; but as he was unable to do so for the reason which I have stated, I carried out an intention which I had formed at El Paso, and determined to take the mail through to San Antonio under my own charge. I had a coach and twenty-two mules, and four passengers. To perform the actual labor of this trip, I had two clerks of mine now out of employ by my discharge. Mr. Giddings accompanied me, with two hired men.

December 26.—Birchville, at 10 a. m., weather very pleasant.

December 27.—In our second drive this morning we ascended the cañon leading from the valley of the Rio Grande to the high table lands of this portion of western Texas. We found a change of climate apparent at once. The whole of our journey, from the summit of this pass till we reached Devil's river, in the course of which we had descended from this table land, was cold and uncomfortable, though by no means to the extent of any personal suffering; I may except very cold fingers, while driving, before sunrise.

December 29.—To-day we reached Fort Davis. The officers' quarters, with good oak wood fires, looked more comfortable than our camping on ground; but, for fear of catching cold by the change, I preferred to continue sleeping out of doors.—(See journal of [August 12](#) for my interview with Col. Sewall.)

December 30.—Met an extra of ours going up to Birchville—coach, mules, and complete outfit to take their place in the line. Gave orders for the conductor to take the newspaper mail from Fort Davis, which had been left

behind by the last up mail in consequence of the snow at Birchville. He would meet another coach and send it forward to El Paso.

January 3.—We reached Fort Lancaster at 7 a. m., changed our mail, and started again at 11 a. m. It commenced snowing as we left Fort Lancaster, and continued to snow so rapidly that I deemed it prudent to stop about 3 o'clock p. m. We halted in a cañon 9 miles from the fort, on the edge of the Llano Estacado. It was not safe to attempt to cross this bleak plain in the face of a snow storm, with the road obliterated by the snows. We might have lost our way, or our mules might have perished from being chilled through by standing exposed, after heating themselves in the exertion of hauling the coach. I therefore made a halt and camped for the night. We then drove the mules into a cañon, where they would be partially sheltered from the wind and storm by bushes, made a fire, cooked our dinner, set the guard, and then went to bed, with the snow falling at intervals all night long.

January 4.—A fine morning, with the sun bright and pleasant, the ground covered with snow to the depth of several inches, rendering it almost impossible to roll our coach to-day. The snow would have clung to the hoofs of our mules and to the tire of our coach so as to render our progress very slow. Under these circumstances I deemed it best to send the mail forward on mules in charge of one of the two hired men, accompanied by a passenger equally familiar with the road, who very kindly volunteered to accompany the mail and rider. They each took a riding mule, also a third mule packed with the mail, provisions, and a few small articles. These animals they were to change at Fort Clarke, with yet another change, if possible, at Dharris. (They made the trip to San Antonio in good order and in time, delivering the mail at 6 a. m. the morning of the 9th.) This morning, after the mail was gone, I sent our mules back to Fort Lancaster with directions to have them well fed with grain, returning them to our camp by night with an additional supply of grain and provisions if the snow melted so that we could proceed. In the course of the afternoon, the weather looking threatening, I sent one of my clerks, who volunteered to go on foot, to the quartermaster with a request that he would send out a team of mules and haul us back to the fort; this request he promptly acceded to, and we reached there about 10 o'clock at night. Having despatched the mail, there was now no cause for our immediate haste; I, therefore, determined to

recruit my animals at Fort Lancaster before continuing our journey. With this view I remained there for three days.

January 7.—This morning we left Fort Lancaster the second time. We had for company a party under escort to Fort Hudson. This evening we met the mail coach which left San Antonio December 24. It had been detained several days by high water in the Medina river at Castroville, being afterwards caught in the same snow storm that had delayed our coach; like us they were compelled to lie by and wait a day or two for the snow to disappear. As they had but commenced their journey to Birchville, they could not send their mail forward on pack animals as we did. Again, as the up mail contains newspapers it is much heavier than the down mail.

Nothing of special interest occurred on the road to San Antonio differing from the usual routine which I have sketched from day to day. I staid at Fort Hudson and at Fort Clarke long enough to attend to the business of the line at each of those posts. I did this in the absence of any one to take my place, though I was yet in doubt as to my own position.

January 17.—Reached San Antonio to-night.

January 18.—Received to-day a revocation of my authority from Mrs. Birch, the revocation dated the 26th of last October; I ceased at once to act for the line and prepared to come north, giving the new local agent every information the limited time permitted.

January 19.—I left for Washington.

The question is frequently asked as to whether we have a well defined road all the way from San Antonio to San Diego. To this I answer that it is as plain a road as any stage route over which a mail is carried in coaches for your department. An emigrant would find it as impossible to miss his way when once on our road either going to or returning from California, as he would if traveling in a country where guide posts marked every cross-road.

An examination of my table of distances will show four military posts between San Antonio and Birchville; from Birchville to La Mesilla we have a settled country all the way; from La Mesilla to Tucson, we have not at present any military posts, but I am informed that the War Department contemplates placing two forts in this portion of Arizona, immediately on the completion of the Fort Yuma and El Paso wagon road. In the whole

distance of 460 miles from Tucson to San Diego, one hundred and fifteen miles is the longest distance at present between any of our mail stations.

An emigrant passing over our route will meet or be overtaken by a mail party four times every month, while from our mail conductors he can always obtain the reliable information as to road, wood, water, grass, camping places, with directions where to find safe valleys in which to feed his stock for a few weeks, and transmit messages, letters, or any desired intelligence from friends before or behind him. I have received many expressions of satisfaction from emigrants I met on the road, and, also, from others in California, who, last season, on the trip, realized, in a small way, the advantages of the mail, in these respects to overland emigration.

When camping, after a drive of about ten miles, we unharness in the middle of the road, and from one end of our route to the other, from San Antonio to San Diego, the road can almost be measured by the ashes of our camp fires.

From Fort Hudson, in Texas, to Tazotal, on the Gila, a distance of 1,200 miles, nearly the whole of our route is over an elevated, dry country. When but a small amount of labor was requisite at first to make a road suited to staging, only a portion of this has ever had any labor bestowed on it beyond that of passing trains. From San Antonio to El Paso, a distance of 651 miles, the road was opened in the year 1849, by a government train of several hundred wagons, *en route* to El Paso; since that time, the continual passage of government and freighting trains, as also of the Santa Fé and San Antonio mail coaches, had beaten down an excellent road, before the labors of the El Paso and Fort Yuma wagon road expedition commenced.

That portion of our route situated between El Paso and the Pimos villages has never had even a government train to open it. Col. Leach's labors will be of great service in straitening it, finding new watering places, enlarging others, and in constructing tanks, if the appropriation will admit of such an expenditure. A consultation of the items of my own journey, where I have put down each day's advance, will tend to show the excellent condition of our roads, for we used a coach all the way from San Antonio to San Diego, sometimes drawn by six, never by less than four mules.

There are a number of formidable looking ranges of mountains upon all the maps, running across Arizona, north and south, which look to be barriers almost impassable without a great expenditure of time and money. Our road

we found to be *through*, rather than *over*, these mountains; although they appeared formidable at a distance, yet, on approaching, they generally proved to be isolated buttes, with our road winding around them by easy grades through the valleys, or else passing over some low span or saddle, no way impeding staging. These passes in the mountains seemed to be formed by nature on purpose for a road. The speed our coaches are making through these mountain ranges is the best evidence of their easy and expeditious passage. By my journal of August 25, it will be noticed that the speed we made from Cook's spring, through the Sierra Madre mountains to and beyond the Mimbres river, was 21 miles in five hours; through all the other mountain passes we made much the same rate of speed.

Having formed my ideas of mountains and mountain roads from a pretty extensive experience among the Sierra Nevada of California, was very forcibly struck by the fact of not meeting a regular chain of mountains all the way from San Antonio until I reached the coast range of California, eighty miles from San Diego. I wish to call particular attention to the distinction between ranges of mountains like the Alleghanies and Sierra Nevada, and the system of isolated buttes scattered over portions of our line and around which we pass by valley roads well adapted to speed. The mountains south of the Gila, and its immediate neighborhood, do not interfere with our road; they come up close to the river in many places, but leave an ample passage way for our road around the bases. These mountains are mostly what the Mexicans term *Mesas*; high hills, flat on their tops. It appears as if the plain had formerly been level with the tops of the hills, some hundreds of feet higher than it is now. This same appearance of *Mesas* is found along the Pecos.

On the 15th of November, looking northward from our station at the Maricopa Wells, I could plainly see that the high mountains to the north of the Gila, standing in a bold relief against the sky, were covered at their summits with a cap of snow, glistening in the pleasant sun of the valley, where we were. Abundance of rain had fallen throughout the Gila valley this season, but no cold weather had come as yet; we naturally concluded that the rain of the valley was snow on the tops of the mountains. In the day time we found it so pleasant that bathing was our constant practice, though the nights were cool and damp from heavy dews. I am informed that all or most of these valleys north of the Gila have a rich soil, capable of

sustaining a large population. I trust, on some future trip, to be able to explore them, as they are situated within what is likely to become a portion of the new Territory of Arizona, through the whole length of which our line passes. It was among some of the valleys to which I refer, that John R. Bartlett, esq., found evidences of a race of men long since extinct, who must have been superior to the present Indians of the country.

At present we have no good road directly over the coast range of mountains from Lassator's ranch to Vallecito on the desert, but the enterprise of the people of San Diego will secure us one at an early day. When I came over the mountains on my way east, there was a large working party of Indians, under Mr. Lassator, diligently using the means which had been subscribed in the county for a road over the mountains.

Wood, water, and grass, are the emigrant's necessities in crossing our continent. Over our route we have enough of these for all purposes of staging or emigration. Through the country over which we pass, though there is enough water for emigration and staging, yet there is but one river not usually fordable; I refer to the Colorado of the West. This is a great deal in its favor as a stage road. If it were a heavy timbered country, it would not be likely to be so well grassed, as it would be sure to have large rivers troublesome to cross, and need an immense labor cutting down timber to open a road. As to grass, it is wonderfully provided all the way to our Maricopa station. Wood is generally scarce on our route. From San Antonio to San Felipe creek, a distance of one hundred and fifty miles, there is an abundance of wooded country; post oaks and mezquit flats are quite numerous. Along Devil's river, for a distance of twenty miles, there is plenty of wood.

At Forts Lancaster and Davis, oak wood is hauled from a distance of seven miles to supply the military posts. Along the Rio Grande universally the fuel is the root of the mezquit tree, a sort of underground forest; it burns with as hot a fire as hickory wood, and makes superior charcoal. Cottonwood is used along the Rio Grande valley, being the fuel used in some places. We found wood scarce all the way from the Rio Grande to the Maricopas; from thence to Fort Yuma along the Gila abundant; then it is scarce over the desert; at the watering places, however, enough can be found in spots not remote from the wells; once among the San Diego mountains there is wood enough. Over these portions of our road where we

find no wood at the springs or watering holes, and for want of time cannot wander off among the mountain gulches to look for it, we secure enough for all purposes of cooking from the great abundance of roots generally found just cropping out of the ground; these make an excellent fire.

An examination of my table of distances will show no want of water along the route; all my measurements are to and from well known watering places. From San Antonio our road is extremely well watered until we reach the head of the San Pedro or Devil's river, a distance of 218 miles; going west thence, we have a jornada of forty-four miles; thence another of thirty miles, between permanent roads, on to the Pecos. In the rainy season there are plenty of places in this distance where the water stands in natural tanks in the rocks, or in cañons. This stretch of forty-four miles is the longest we have on the road between permanent water stations; it forms however no great obstacle to staging. We haul water for ourselves in kegs, and the mules, having to go about twelve to sixteen hours without it, do not suffer in consequence. We have no scarcity of water in Arizona for our present purposes.—(See [schedule](#) of distances.) Our watering places on the desert west of Fort Yuma are by no means far apart, but the supply is limited at all times. It will be a matter of absolute necessity to enlarge them before the overland emigration of this spring reaches the desert. The improvement of those now used, as well as the digging of others, will be very easily accomplished.

I am of opinion that the chances of procuring water by boring artesian wells on the elevated table lands, over which our road runs, may be considered as very limited. At any rate, as a practical mode of procuring water for us, it will not do. Supposing Captain Pope should demonstrate the feasibility of boring these artesian wells, even then private individuals cannot afford to make them, neither can they wait for government to do so. We should be compelled, in staging across the continent at a rate of speed necessitating the erection of stations, to adopt the old Mexican method of building tanks wherever the natural formation of the country admits of it which it does in numerous places along our road.

As for grass, the country through which our road runs is unequalled as a grazing country, in the opinion of practiced men acquainted with the subject. I have heard farmers pronounce the gramma and mezquit grass nearly equal to clover. There is a peculiarity of the grass of this section

which adapts it most admirably to our purpose; when appearing dried up and dead, it contains life and nutriment; an examination will show this on plucking it. When the rains come, instead of our having to wait wholly for new grass to spring up, we find the old dried grass renewing its life, becoming green again, until in a few days the country is covered with an excellent crop of grass, as good as if it had been growing many weeks.

Many of the finest ranches or grazing farms in the State of Sonora were once located in what is now called Arizona; the buildings are at present deserted; the inhabitants have fled from the Apaches, who stole their cattle, as far as possible destroyed the buildings, and murdered or carried into captivity the inhabitants.

The section of the country along the Gila river is commonly pronounced by emigrants the worst portion of the whole southern road across our continent; but even along this river, though it is not superabundantly supplied with grazing lands, no one need let their animals suffer for the want of food. Travellers must take some care in examining to the right and left of the road. To those who have just been passing over the finest grazing lands in the world, where a range of a few hundred yards would suffice for their teams anywhere along the road, the Gila naturally seems a desert. As a fair illustration of the grazing in Arizona, I would state that an overheated horse or mule will actually founder on the rich gramma grass as he would on clover. On nearly all the hills found along the Gila river spots of gramma and quinta or bunch grass are scattered in places. Young willows also grow along the river banks, which are good food for animals. A weed much liked by them and very nutritious is found in many places along the bottoms. Mules are also fond of the fallen leaves of the mezquit tree. By crossing the river and making a little exploration, spots of good grazing can be found on the north side of the Gila. Lastly, there is in the season an abundant supply of excellent food for animals in the mezquit beans which are found on our road along the Gila, from Tezotal to Fort Yuma. These beans fall from the tree as soon as ripe; animals will leave their corn to eat them, as I have proved.

The Indians make a kind of flour from these beans by roasting and then pounding them; they contain a large portion of saccharine matter, so much so that the Pimos manufacture from them a species of syrup. They

commence falling in August; we found a great many under the trees in November, after the emigration had passed down the river.

On my return trip from San Diego I brought my mules into our Maricopa station in a much better condition than when I left Fort Yuma with them. My practice was this: while one of my two teams of mules was working in the coaches for a couple of hours at a walk, I would have the other team under charge of an experienced man, either ahead or behind the coaches, eating their fill of grass, beans, or whatever they could find. At the end of two hours we would change teams, giving the other set of mules their chance for loitering behind to eat.

Sometimes emigrants who are going to California pasture their cattle on the bottom lands of the Colorado river for a few weeks before attempting to cross the desert; others again put on at once, in order to reach as soon as possible the excellent grazing on the coast range. We keep a mulada at Fort Yuma for our changes, which we send out every day to feed in the river bottom, under charge of a Mexican herder, bringing them in at night for safety.

In crossing the Colorado desert of ninety-five miles from Fort Yuma to Carissa there is but little for animals to eat. In some few places arroyos make up to the northward, containing mezquit trees full of beans, but these are limited in number, while they are not situated at the watering places.

In the mountains near Carissa, or at Vallecito, good grazing commences again. I am assured by men familiar with this section of country that good hay can be cut on the mountain sides, a few miles south of the present desert, and hauled on to the line of our road at a fair price. Mezquit beans can also be procured sufficiently near the road to be sold to travellers at reasonable rates. One advantage of our road is, that any emigrant who may be *en route* to California can now leave his stock in Arizona to recruit, while he takes passage for San Diego or along the road to explore for himself the country over which he intends to pass.

The country we stage over is a grazing and mineral country, rather than an agricultural one, though I found no lack of grain along the road. In seasons of rain an abundance of grain is raised all the way from San Antonio to Fort Clarke; from there to Birchville there are no settlements, and the grain has to be hauled from either end to the military posts between these two points;

along the Rio Grande the whole country is capable of cultivation. Wheat, corn, beans, pumpkins, and onions of very superior flavor are all raised in great abundance by the Spanish population.

Flour of an excellent quality is made at a mill on the Rio Grande, a couple of miles above El Paso; it is owned and managed by Simeon Hart, esq., who is the contractor for supplying with flour all the forts in that section of the country.

In many places along the Rio Grande our road lies through cornfields miles in length. At Tucson we found no difficulty in purchasing corn and barley for our mules; flour from wheat grown in the Santa Cruz valley, and ground at Tucson by the Mexicans; also beans and onions.

At Maricopa station we bought, of the Indians, flour, beans, peas, green and dried pumpkins, chickens, eggs, corn, and wheat. At Fort Yuma every thing has to be imported. There is a considerable importation there of flour, pinola, pounded parched corn, jerked beef, and sugar, called pinoche, all of which comes on pack animals from Sonora; no doubt a large trade will spring up from this when Colorado City becomes of consequence. Nearly everything is now brought from San Francisco by way of the Gulf of California and steamer up the Colorado river.

Arizona ought to be supplied through Guyamas, a Mexican port on the Gulf of California.

Ours is emphatically a stage road. If it were a rich agricultural country all the way from San Antonio to San Diego, it would be impossible for a stage line to cross it in schedule time until some remote day, when the whole distance shall have been settled, and towns built at convenient distances, with good roads connecting them. Our present road would be called a superior one in any State for thirteen hundred miles of its length, and a fair road the remainder of the distance, save twenty-two miles of sand in the Colorado desert, from Cook's Wells to Alamo Mucho.

In the valley of the Rio Grande I had an application from an old mountain man, who wanted a situation as guide. This man had trapped beaver in all the principal streams falling into the Gila and Colorado rivers. He said the trappers pronounced our present route across Arizona a good one at all seasons of the year.

I had a good opportunity of knowing the nature of the climate we have to contend with. Leaving San Antonio in August, and going directly through, I passed over the road in the hottest months of the year. Then, leaving San Diego October 23, and spending nearly three months returning, I experienced the winter weather over the same country. It was very warm in San Antonio in July; but when we had once commenced ascending to the table lands of Texas, the heat became comparatively moderated, with nights particularly pleasant. In going down the Gila, where we were descending toward the level of the sea, the heat was very great, so much so that, for comfort, and having a full moon, we travelled by night and lay by during the middle of the day. In my experience of the heat on the Gila, which looks so formidable, as marked by the thermometer, I suffered much less with that instrument indicating a hundred and over than I have suffered in the Atlantic States with the thermometer at 85 or 90. The air was pure and clear, the heat produced a copious perspiration, and gave no feeling of oppression in breathing.

In my plans for returning across the continent, the recollection of the hot days along the Gila, or on the Colorado desert, never present themselves to me as any serious inconvenience. The heat does not oppress animals any more than it does men. Our mail carriers, who regularly cross the desert, frequently complain of the blinding influence of the sun reflected in their eyes from the bright sands; I never heard any of them complain of unpleasant effects from the heat, and we have a number of men employed who have traversed this desert for several years past. In returning to San Antonio, through Arizona and Texas, I experienced the northers a number of times, having been delayed once by snow; but none of our party ever suffered anything more than the natural annoyances incidental to wet feet and damp blankets. I make here some few extracts from my journal about the cold I experienced on our route:

December 5.—At El Paso have had a week of cold weather, with an occasional strong north wind during the time. Ice formed in a pond 100 feet across in the rear of the house; ice also made in the acequias, but the river was barely skimmed over once very early in the morning. Only once in a great many years, in El Paso, has the ice been thick enough to put up a few tons in an ice house.

December 9.—The mail coach came into El Paso from Tucson, and the conductor reported a norther, accompanied by snow, in the Mimbres. It fell on them the same day we had a norther at El Paso, the 5th, as above; the snow melted as it fell, so that by making a longer morning drive than common he reached the shelter of the trees at the Mimbres; none of his mules were chilled by being exposed without blankets, after unharnessing. The same conductor reports a snow squall on the previous trip, without any detention in either case to the mail, and without the snow lying on the ground at all; it melted as it fell both times.

A letter per this mail from our train going west reports the weather cold enough in the night to freeze water in the canteens, but no one suffering from cold by sleeping on the ground. During the day it was bright and warm, forming a pleasant contrast to the night.

At El Paso, December 9, we received advices of the northern wagon road expedition having returned for the winter. I consulted Colonel Leach, superintendent of the El Paso and Fort Yuma wagon road as to his movements; he assured me he had no intention of going into winter quarters, but, on the contrary, should continue on the road through the winter months; in fact, he deemed them the best suited to his purposes of shortening and improving the road.

The surgeon of Fort Lancaster, who keeps a meteorological journal, said they had not as much snow in that part of Texas during the whole of the past six years taken together as had fallen during the present winter. The snow which fell on the 3d had so far disappeared from the ground as to allow the animals to graze sufficiently, but I waited in order to accompany a detachment of mounted infantry going on a scout as far as Fort Hudson.

January 6.—The snow had entirely disappeared.

January 7.—We camped to-night on the Llano Estacado, about half way across it; there was not a particle of snow on the ground. We found one advantage from the snow, it had melted and run into a natural stone tank, giving us abundance of water for ourselves and stock; it will last some weeks. An expense of a few hundred dollars in building up the sides of the tank would make it capable of holding several millions of gallons of water.

The Llano Estacado is here very narrow; we cross the extreme southern portion of it immediately south of us. Not a mile distant, I saw the cañons and broken gulches running eastward to the Devil's river, and westward to the Pecos.

I never had a case of sickness among either men or passengers during my whole trip, excepting a little annoyance from an over indulgence in fruit in the valley of the Rio Grande. The salubrious air must be conducive to health. Such is the purity and clearness of the atmosphere that the stars shine at night with a brilliancy unknown in this section of the country; cloudy days or nights are an exception, and the stars at night actually give light enough to enable us on our night drives, of which we have a considerable number, to find the road. It can be seen, for some distance ahead of the mules, very plainly.

Climatic boundary on the west.

October 24.—The coast range of mountains, which approaches the sea in San Diego county, is the climatic boundary between California and Arizona. Our stock is kept at Lassator's, 48 miles, nearly due west, from San Diego, in a beautiful valley among the mountains; in San Diego they have a charming climate the year round, while among the mountains snow falls occasionally during the winter, which in the valley below turns to rain. The snow remains on the ground but a day or two. In California there is no rain from March until October, but showers occasionally fall in these valleys during the summer months, when it is the rainy season in Sonora.

The exploring party I sent over the mountain on the 15th of September were rained on all one night. We saw clouds to the westward, but not one drop of rain fell upon us.

By reference to my journal it will be noticed that rain fell on us at intervals all the way from the opening of the Rio Grande valley until I came near to Fort Yuma. While the coast along the Pacific was, in September and October, parched with a drought, compelling rancheros to send their cattle into the mountains; our contractor was cutting hay to send over to our station on the desert. Lassator's is twelve miles from the top of the coast range, which we there descend by a mule path for several miles on our way to Vallecito, though a good road can be made with a moderate amount of money. After crossing the desert, emigrants usually give their stock a run of

the excellent grazing valleys in these mountains, before proceeding further on their journey.

It is hardly possible for me to do more than sketch a few of the changes which our road has produced in the country through which we pass.

The War Department uses the facilities offered by our line for a regular semi-monthly correspondence with seven military posts.

Persons interested in mining pursuits are now looking with great interest towards the silver and copper mines of Arizona. Our mail not only carries the correspondence which takes the money to the mining parties, but regularly bring reports of their success, while passengers are, all the while, taking our line to Arizona; our stations afford stopping places, and our agents information to all who prefer their own mode of conveyance; such travellers are numerous.

The newly appointed consul for Guyamas takes our stage as far as Tucson, starting from San Antonio, Texas.

Our line is already forming the basis of a new State, rich in minerals, half way between Texas and California.

Very respectfully,

I. C. WOODS,
Superintendent S. A. & S. D. Mail Line.

Hon. A. V. BROWN,
Postmaster General.

Accompanying this please find the measurements from point to point on the whole road from San Antonio to San Diego, with names of the watering places.

Table of distances, and from one watering-place to another from starting point.

From San Antonio to Leon river	6.53
From Leon to Castroville, "Medina" river	18.00
From Castroville to Dharris "Saco" river	25.28

From Dharris to Ranchero creek	8.38	
From Ranchero creek to Sabinal creek	3.94	
From Sabinal creek to Camanche creek	5.00	
From Camanche creek to Rio Frio	8.46	
From Rio Frio to Head of Leona "Uvalde"	6.08	
From Uvalde to Nueces	9.04	
From Nueces to Turkey creek	10.27	
From Turkey creek to Elm creek	15.23	
From Elm creek to Las Moras river, Fort Clarke	7.13	
	—	123.34
From Fort Clarke to Piedra Pinto	7.00	
From Piedra Pinto to Maverick creek	8.86	
From Maverick creek to San Felipe	12.61	
From San Felipe to first crossing of San Pedro or Devil's river	10.22	
From First Crossing to Painted Caves	2.54	
From Painted Caves to California Spring	15.73	
From California Spring to Willow Spring	2.00	
From Willow Spring to Fort Hudson, or second crossing of San Pedro or Devil's river	16.39	
	—	75.35
From Fort Hudson to Head of San Pedro or Devil's river	19.50	
From Head of river to Howard Springs	44.00	
From Howard Springs to Live Oak creek	30.44	
From Live Oak creek to Fort Lancaster	3.00	
	—	96.94

From Fort Lancaster to Pecos	4.29	
From Pecos Crossing to Pecos Spring	6.00	
From Pecos Spring to Leaving of Pecos	32.26	
From Leaving of Pecos to Arroyo Escondido	16.26	
From Arroyo Escondido to Escondido Spring	8.58	
From Escondido Spring to Camanche Spring	19.40	
From Camanche Spring to Leon Hole	8.88	
From Leon Hole to Hackberry pond	11.00	
From Hackberry pond to Limpia creek	32.00	
From Limpia creek to Fort Davis	18.86	
	——	157.53
From Fort Davis to Point of Rocks	10.00	
From Point of Rocks to Barree Springs	8.42	
From Barree Springs to Deadman's Hole	13.58	
From Deadman's Hole to Van Horn's Wells	32.83	
From Van Horn's Wells to Eagle Springs	19.74	
From Eagle Springs to first camp on Rio Grande	31.42	
From first camp on Rio Grande to Birchville	35.00	
	——	150.99
From Birchville to San Eleazario	24.80	
From San Eleazario to Socorro	5.45	
From Socorro to Isletta	3.10	
From Isletta to El Paso	14.14	
	——	47.49
From El Paso to Cottonwood	22.00	
From Cottonwood to Fort Fillmore	22.00	

From Fort Fillmore to La Mesilla	6.00	
	——	50.00
From La Mesilla to Cook's Spring	65.00	
From Cook's Spring to Rio Mimbres	18.00	
From Rio Mimbres to Ojo La Vaca	17.00	
From Ojo La Vaca to Ojo de Ynez	10.00	
From Ojo de Ynez to Peloncilla	34.00	
From Peloncilla to Rio Saur or San Domingo	18.00	
From Rio Saur to Apache Springs	23.00	
From Apache Springs to Dos Cabezas Springs	9.00	
From Dos Cabezas Springs to Dragon Springs	26.00	
From Dragon Springs to mouth of Quercos cañon	18.00	
From mouth of Quercos cañon to San Pedro crossing	6.00	
From San Pedro to Cienega	20.00	
From Cienega to Cienega creek	13.00	
From Cienega creek to Mission San Xavier	20.00	
From Mission to Tucson	8.00	
	——	305
From Tucson to Pico Chico mountain	5.00	
From Pico Chico to first camp on Gila	35.00	
From first camp on Gila to Maricopa Wells	29.00	
	——	99.00
From Maricopa Wells to Tezotal, across Jornada	40.00	
From Tezotal to Ten-mile camp	10.00	
From Ten-mile camp to Murderer's grave	8.00	

From Murderer's grave to Oatman's Flat, 1st crossing of Gila	15.00	
From Oatman's Flat to 2d crossing of Gila	25.00	
From 2d crossing of Gila to Peterman's station	32.00	
From Peterman's station to Antelope Peak	20.00	
From Antelope Peak to Little Corral	24.00	
From Little Coral to Fort Yuma	16.00	
	——	190.00
From Fort Yuma to Pilot Knob	7.00	
From Pilot Knob to Cook's Wells	13.00	
From Cook's Wells to Alamo Mucho	21.94	
From Alamo Mucho to Indian Wells	20.94	
From Indian Wells to Carissa creek	32.24	
	——	95.12
From Carissa creek to Vallecito	18.00	
From Vallecito to Lassator's ranch	18.00	
From Lassator's ranch to Julian's ranch	7.00	
From Julian's ranch to Williams' ranch	7.00	
From Williams' ranch to Ames' ranch	14.00	
From Ames' ranch to Mission San Diego	16.00	
From Mission to San Diego	5.00	
	——	85.00

Recapitulation.

San Antonio to Fort Clarke	123.34
Fort Clarke to Fort Hudson	75.35
Fort Hudson to Fort Lancaster	96.94

Fort Lancaster to Fort Davis	157.53	
Fort Davis to Birchville	150.99	
Birchville to El Paso	47.49	
	————	651.64
El Paso to La Mesilla		50.00
La Mesilla to Tucson		305.00
Tucson to Maricopa		99.00
Maricopa to Fort Yuma		190.00
Fort Yuma to Carissa		95.12
Carissa to San Diego		85.00
		————
San Antonio to San Diego		1,475.76
		=====

Itinerary of my own journey across the continent.

August	1.—From San Antonio to Castroville	25 miles.
	2.—From Castroville to 9 miles east of Uvalde	46 ”
	3.—From camp to 11 miles west of Turkey creek	40 ”
	4.—From camp to near San Felipe creek	40 ”
	5.—From camp to 10 miles east of Fort Hudson	35 ”
	6.—From camp to 10 miles west of San Pedro	44 ”
	7.—From camp to 6 miles east of Live Oak creek	53 ”
	8.—From camp to 6 miles above Pecos spring	28 ”
	9.—From camp to Escondido creek, 8 miles east of the spring	44 ”
	10.—From camp to 10 miles west of	46 ”
	11.—From camp to Limpia creek	33 ”

	12.—From camp to Fort Davis	19	”
	13.—From Fort Davis to 7 miles west of Dead Man’s Hole	42	”
	14.—From camp to 8 miles west of Eagle Springs	51	”
	15.—From camp to 10 miles south of Birchville	49	”
	16.—From camp to Socorro	40	”
	17.—From Socorro to Franklin, El Paso	17	”
	18, 19, 20, 21.—In El Paso.		
	22.—From El Paso to Fort Fillmore	44	”
	23.—From Fort Fillmore to Picacho village, 6 miles west of Mesilla	12	”
	24.—From Picacho village to 9 miles east of Cook’s Spring	50	”
	25.—From camp to mouth of Burro Mount cañon, near Ojo de Ynez	55	”
	26.—From camp to 9 miles east of River Saur	43	”
	27.—From camp to 9 miles west of Dos Cabezas Spring	50	”
	28.—From camp to ford of San Pedro river	40	”
	29.—From camp to Mission San Xavier	53	”
	30.—From Mission San Xavier to 30 miles west of Tucson	38	”
	31.—From camp to 1-mile camp on Gila	40	”
Sept.	1.—From camp to Tezotal	69	”
	2.—From Tezotal to second crossing of Gila	58	”
	3.—From second crossing to Antelope Peak	52	”
	4.—From Antelope Peak to Fort Yuma	40	”
	5.—From Fort Yuma to Alamo Mucho	42	”

6.—From Alamo Mucho to Carissa creek	53	”
7.—From Carissa creek to Lassator’s	36	”
8.—From Lassator’s to San Diego	49	”

1,476 miles.

Making the trip personally from San Antonio to San Diego in thirty-eight days.

[From the San Antonio Herald.]

A few notes and distances from San Antonio to San Diego.

The following information in relation to the distances from this place to San Diego, has been obtained from the superintendent of the S. A. & S. D. Mail Stage Company, who has passed over the route and back, and the statements as to distances and the nature of the route may be implicitly relied on:

1. The distance from San Antonio to El Paso is 652 miles, and the character of the route is so well known to most of our readers that we deem it unnecessary to enter into any description of it. Grass and water are considered sufficiently abundant. The road passes by a number of the military posts, and though Indians are occasionally met with, they have seldom made any hostile demonstrations, and have never, but once, made an attack upon the train.
2. From El Paso to Messilla Valley in the Gadsden Purchase, the route running up the east bank of the Rio Grande to Fort Fillmore, (N. M.) where it crosses the river into the Messilla Valley, the distance is 50 miles.
3. From Messilla Valley to Tucson the distance is 305 miles. This portion of the route is remarkably fine travelling, with good grass and water. The streams on this section are the Mimbres and San Pedro, both fordable, and usually crossed with but little trouble. The Apache Indians are met with occasionally on this route, yet the mail party which here consists of eight

men, has never been attacked in making some thirty-two trips over the route.

4. From Tucson to Maricopa Wells, (Pimos Villages,) is 99 miles. On this portion of the route the mail is carried by two men. Very few Indians are seen, and they are harmless. The Maricopa Wells are at the further end of a beautiful and fertile valley, occupied by the Pimos Indians, who raise corn and other grain in considerable quantities.—(See [Journal](#).) On this portion of the route, and indeed, throughout the entire distance from San Antonio to San Diego, the road is well defined, and is a finely beaten level track, with just enough gravel for the most part to make it pleasant travelling.

5. From Maricopa Wells down the river Gila to Fort Yuma is 190 miles. On this portion of the route the grass, though not abundant, is yet sufficient for the maintenance of trains and herds.—(See [Journal](#).) Few Indians on the route, and they not dangerous. The mail train between these points consists of three men. Fort Yuma is situated on the west bank of the Great Colorado of the West, and just opposite the junction of the Gila with that stream. There is a splendid large ferry-boat on the Colorado here, sufficient to cross a six-horse stage. The river is about as large as the Ohio at Wheeling. This portion of the road is travelled considerably by Californians who carry on mining operations in the Gadsden Purchase. It is the opinion of all who have seen that region that it possesses the finest silver mines in the world, together with fine quantities of gold on the streams north of the Gila. These mines are now little known and but slightly valued, because of the proximity of the Indians, and their remoteness from mining facilities.

6. From Fort Yuma to Carissa creek is 95 miles. This section embraces the “great bugbear” known as the “Great Colorado Desert.” Between the two points there are three watering places on the direct route, whilst there are others that may be reached by a slight deflection. The mail party here consists of two men.

7. From Carissa creek to San Diego is 85 miles, its whole extent. This is by a new route, and at present not open to wagons its whole extent, but which, by a little work in the mountain passes, can be made an excellent road. The mail is now carried over this new route. The old route, over which the stages have to pass, is 125 miles. Over this section the mail is carried by a single person.

Transcriber's note

Minor punctuation errors have been changed without notice. Inconsistencies in italics, spelling, and hyphenization have been standardized.

In this version on pages [39-41](#) the whole numbers in the tables have .00 added at the end to aid in lining up the numbers.

The author often refers to previous entries in his journal i.e., "(see journal, August 2.)" If those exist in this extract, then there is a link to that entry.

Spelling has been retained as originally published except for the changes below.

Page 14 : “during the moring”	“during the morning”
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Page 14 : “in charge of the coporal”	“in charge of the corporal”
--	-----------------------------

Page 17 : “paying off the trooops”	“paying off the troops”
--	-------------------------

Page 18 : “made two arragements”	“made two arrangements”
--	-------------------------

Page 30 : “Department contemplate”	“Department contemplates”
--	---------------------------

Page 35 : “nature of the climate wit”	“nature of the climate we”
---	----------------------------

Page 35 : “go ee directly through”	“going directly through”
--	--------------------------

Page 35 : “hottest months gof hn”	“hottest months of the”
---	-------------------------

Page [37](#): “drop of rain feel
upon us”

“drop of rain fell upon
us”

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK REPORT TO HON.
A. V. BROWN, POSTMASTER-GENERAL ***

Updated editions will replace the previous one—the old editions will be renamed.

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